

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

The Unopened Gift

a novel



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The Unopened Gift

a novel of Véspera



VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This is a work of fiction. Véspera, its houses and its people are imagined, and any resemblance to real persons is the resemblance true stories bear to one another. This novel has a self-knowledge sibling: if Dádiva hurts you in real places, the name of what she carries is in “The Woman Who Is Afraid to Receive”, in the Prosperity collection. A story understands, but it does not replace care: in the deep matters, seek support. You deserve the same care you give.

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FROM THE REGISTER OF VÉSPERA

From the register of Véspera

In the register of the village, by the hand of the Keepers who passed through the book, is found:

Dádiva — gift — daughter of people of the village, born on a Sunday of festival, and the name was a promise and a prophecy.

The mother, who received the bread of others with a shame that could be seen from the street, wished her daughter to be a gift to the world, to give instead of to ask, to stand always on the side of the one who offers and never on the side of the one who holds out a hand, because on the side of the one who holds out a hand the mother knew the cold, and she wished to spare her daughter that cold with a name that would set her, from the cradle, to giving.

The register says who gave whom their name, who cared for whom, who offered what. It does not say why there are those who give everything and accept nothing, nor what wall is raised on the side of receiving, nor what gift it is that sits at home, unopened, while no one knows what waits inside it.

For that, books such as this one are needed.

CHAPTER ONE

There was no need



Dádiva had a phrase she said more often than good morning, and she always said it the same way, with the same smile and the same small drawing back of the body, like someone parrying a blow with practised ease: there was no need.

She said it when she was offered something, and she was offered a great deal, because Dádiva was the one who cared for half the village and the village, in its way, repaid her: a neighbour would bring her eggs in thanks for a few days' company kept with a sick relative, and Dádiva would say there was no need, and would contrive not to take the eggs, or would take them backing away, as if they were hot; someone would thank her with a compliment, would say to her you're an angel, Dádiva, I don't know what would become of us without you, and

Dádiva would say there was no need, give over with that, anyone would have done it, and she would return the compliment before feeling it, before letting it in, like someone returning a letter without opening it. This was Dádiva's art, the art of a whole life: to give with both hands and to receive with none, to stand always on the side of the one who offers and never, never, on the side of the one who accepts, because to accept, for her, had a taste she could not bear, the taste of being in debt, the taste of coming down from the place of the one who gives to the place of the one who is in need, and from that place Dádiva fled as one flees a thing that truly does harm.

And it was noticed, in *Véspera*, that small drawing back of her body when something was offered her, though nobody knew how to read it: it was a half-step backward, a shrug of the shoulders, a way of putting her hands behind her back, the small gestures of one defending herself against a thing coming towards her, and the thing coming was only a dish, a kindness, a thank-you, but Dádiva defended herself against it as against a danger, because to Dádiva it was a danger, the danger of receiving, and her body, which never drew back to give, which always went forward to offer, always drew back to receive, as though receiv-

ing and giving were, in her body, two opposite movements, one open and easy, the giving, and another closed and impossible, the receiving.

And it did harm, it is true, though she had never told anyone why, nor herself in words. It came from far off, the harm of receiving, it came from her mother's house, but of that the book will speak further on; for now it is enough to say that Dádiva had reached the age of forty-eight as, in *Véspera*, the very personification of giving: she cared for the old whose children were far away, she watched over the sick, she ran the errands of those who could not, she carried soup to whoever fell ill, she helped at the births and at the funerals, which are the two ends where a village most needs hands, and she did all of this without charging, without complaint, without ever saying she was tired, with a readiness that seemed to have no bottom and that the whole village took for a blessing, without noticing that a spring which always gives and never receives is not a bottomless blessing: it is a spring emptying itself from within, slowly, and that one day, if no one lets it fill, runs dry.

Dádiva's days were all alike and all full, and full of the same thing: of other people. She rose early, and before thinking of herself she was already thinking of who needed her that day, who was bedridden, who had been left alone, who had a child far off and a sorrow near, and she left the house with the list of others in her head and no place in it for herself. And the list was always long: there was old Aniceto, who had lost his wife and could not fry an egg, and to whom Dádiva went to put the lunch on the fire; there was Romana, bound to a wheelchair since a fall, to whom Dádiva went to open the windows and shift her position so as not to make sores; there was the house of the Tristãos, where the mother had died in childbed and three children and a lost father had been left, and where Dádiva came in as one comes into her own home, washing, mending, combing heads. She went through the village from door to door, giving, doing, tending, and came home at night tired in a way she called good, the tiredness of one who has spent herself entirely on others, and which was, in truth, the tiredness of one who never lets herself be filled, the dry tiredness of a spring that gives without receiving. And the village loved her for this, and said so, and Dádiva grew with the village's love as a plant grows towards the sun, but it was a love from afar, the love one has for whoever

serves us, and Dádiva, who had the love of the whole village, had no one's love close, because to have love close one must let someone draw near, and to draw near is to give and to receive, and Dádiva let near only those who came to receive from her, never those who came to give to her.

She had been widowed young. Bento, the husband — his name means blessed — a good and quiet man, a carpenter with good hands, had died some years before of a trouble in the chest that took him slowly, and since then Dádiva's house had grown more silent and she more giving still, as if the giving were the way of not feeling his absence, of filling with others the emptiness he had left, and the village, which noticed everything, said that Dádiva, poor thing, had thrown herself into the service of others so as not to think, and was half right; the other half, which the village did not see, was that Bento had been the only person Dádiva had let, in life, give her something, care for her a little.

And there had been, in his death, a sign of all this that the village had seen and had not known how to read. On the day of Bento's funeral, the neighbour women, who knew Dádiva and loved her in their way, organised themselves, as one organises in Véspera around whoever suffers a loss, and filled the house

with food, and wished to stay, wished to keep vigil with her, wished to give her the lap that is given to widows; and Dádiva, on the day she most needed to be held up in all her life, on the day she buried the only man who knew how to receive her, did what she always did: she thanked them, and sent them home. She said go and rest, you have your own lives, I'll be all right, and she stayed alone in the house full of dishes she did not touch, keeping vigil over her husband with no one at her side, because not even in her greatest grief did Dádiva know how to let anyone come to her, and the village remarked, on its way out, that Dádiva was strong, that she bore everything alone, without understanding that that strength was the same loneliness as ever, now dressed in mourning. And Dádiva spent the first night of widowhood alone, on purpose, and she was cold, the cold of feet by the hearth that no one rubbed now, and she put it down to Bento's absence, without seeing that the cold was her own door, shut even on the night she most needed to open it.

And Bento had known how to do it in a way no one else ever had, with the gentle cunning of quiet men, never head-on, for head-on Dádiva always drew back. She remembered, now, a thing he did that at the time had seemed to her only a habit and

that was, she understood it late, the whole key: when he saw her tired from a day of caring for others, Bento did not say rest, woman, you do too much, for that was offering and Dádiva refused what was offered; Bento would sit beside her at the hearth, saying nothing, and would begin to rub her feet with his thick carpenter's hands, slowly, in silence, like one doing a thing he himself felt like doing and not a favour for her, and Dádiva, who would have drawn back from a favour, did not draw back from that, because it did not have the face of a gift, it had the face of a habit, and Bento, clever in his way, had discovered that the only way to care for Dádiva was to care for her without it looking like care, was to come in under her wall rather than knock at the door on top. And so, at the hearth, with her feet in her husband's hands, Dádiva, and only with him, and only so, let herself, now and then, be received; and when he died that chink closed, and there died with Bento the only person who knew the way under the wall, and the wall shut for good, with no one on the inside who knew how to open it, and Dádiva's feet stayed cold by the hearth, and she put the cold down to his absence, without understanding that the cold was older than Bento and that Bento had only warmed it, for a few years, without ever having cured it.

There remained her daughter. Estima — esteem — lived nearby, married, with her own life, and loved her mother with a love that had a thorn in it, and the thorn was this: that Estima had never, in all her life, managed to give her mother anything. Everything she tried to give her, Dádiva returned, with the there was no need, with the keep that for yourself, you have your own house, with the I don't need anything, child, and Estima had grown and become a woman with that lack stuck in her throat, the lack of a mother who would let herself be repaid, who would accept from her, at least once, what her mother had given her all her life. Because Estima wanted to repay her mother, not in debt, but in love; she wanted to have, for once, the pleasure of being the one to give, and her mother, with her tireless giving, with her tender refusal of everything, always took that pleasure from her, always left her on the side of the one who receives, which is a good side when there is an exchange, but which hurts when it is the only one they let us hold.

And there was, in Dádiva's house, a sign of all this, a sign that was in plain view of whoever came in and that no one saw because it looked like only an object: on top of a piece of furniture in the front room, against the wall, was a parcel. It was a gift parcel, the paper already a little faded with time, the bow still

tied, and it had never been opened. Estima had given it to her mother three years before, at a birthday, and Dádiva had received it, because one does not refuse a present in a daughter's hands in front of others, but she had not opened it there, she had said afterwards I'll open it at my leisure, and the afterwards had not come, and the parcel had stayed on top of the furniture, three years, with the bow tied, waiting for a leisure Dádiva never found, because leisure was not what was lacking: what was lacking was the courage to receive, to unwrap, to see what her daughter had chosen for her with love and to let that love come in, and Dádiva, who opened her door to half the village to give, had not been able to open, for three years, a parcel a daughter had given her, because to open it was to receive it, and to receive was the one thing Dádiva did not know how to do.

Estima saw the parcel each time she went to her mother's house, and each time she saw it she carried in her breast a small stab, the stab of seeing her present unopened, year after year, in the same place, with the same bow, gathering dust; and at first she had asked, mother, won't you open it?, and Dádiva had said I'll open it, I'll open it, leave it be; and then she had stopped asking, because to ask and to hear the leave it be was worse than the silence, and the parcel had become, between the two of

them, a thing not spoken of, a wound wrapped in gift paper on top of a piece of furniture, saying, to whoever knew how to read it, all that was left to say between that mother and that daughter, which was that one knew how to give and did not know how to receive, and the other wished to give and was not let, and that the two loved each other over the top of it, but with the parcel always there, closed, between them. And the dust gathered on the bow, fine, and each layer of dust was a month, was six months, was a year, and the parcel grew, from being so still, so faithful to its place, almost a piece of furniture itself, a thing of the house, and Dádiva had nearly stopped seeing it, the way one stops seeing what is always in the same place, and that was the worst of all things, that the daughter's love had stayed still long enough to become invisible, to become part of the furniture, to stop hurting from sheer habit.

That morning, Dádiva had gone early to the house of Brandura — gentleness — an elderly neighbour who had fallen ill and was bedridden. Brandura lived at the top of Cedars' Street, in a small, tidy house of a woman left alone, and Dádiva came in as she always came in, without knocking, for she was already like family, and did what she did, with her usual efficiency: she opened the windows to the morning sun, she shook out the

sheets, she changed the bed linen with the patient still in it, with that knack she had of turning a frail body without hurting it, she put water on the fire, she made the broth, she gave it to her by the spoonful, slowly, blowing on each spoonful as one does for a child. And Brandura let her do everything, her eyes set on Dádiva, with an attention Dádiva was not used to receiving, because others, when she served them, thanked her in passing and turned back to their own pain; Brandura did not, Brandura watched her, followed her about the room with her eyes, like one reading. And Dádiva was already on her way out, the bowl in her hand, thinking of the next house, when Brandura, from the bed, took her hand with her weak hand, and held it, and did not let it go, and said a thing Dádiva did not expect and that left her disconcerted: thank you, Dádiva. You let me receive you so well. And Dádiva, who always gave and to whom no one usually said that in that way, with that weight, was already about to answer with the there was no need of always, to draw back her hand, to set down the bowl; but Brandura pressed her hand with the little strength she had, and did not let her draw back, and looked up at her, from the pillow, and added, with the gentle wisdom of those who are bedridden and have time to think and no longer have time to lose: and you, Dádiva, do you let yourself

be received by anyone? Or is it only you giving, always? I notice, you know. For weeks now you've come in here, you do everything, and you never sit down. You never let me give you so much as a glass of water. You don't sit down, Dádiva. And whoever doesn't sit down in anyone's house, it's because she lets herself be received nowhere. Because whoever only gives, my child, also wears out the one who loves her. Mind you, to receive is also a present one makes to whoever loves us.

Dádiva left Brandura's house with that phrase stuck in her, and it was the first time in her life that a thing said by a person she had gone to give to stayed turning over inside her own self. To receive is also a present one makes to whoever loves us. She did not understand it at once, or she understood it and pushed it far off, as she pushed everything that came towards her; but the phrase did not go, it stayed, and through the day, while Dádiva did her rounds, the phrase came back, and came back with Estima's face, with the lack stuck in the daughter's throat, with the unopened parcel on top of the furniture, and Dádiva began to feel, without yet knowing how to say it, that perhaps there was a side of generosity she had never seen, a side in which to give too much, and never to let oneself receive, was not the greatest of goodnesses, was a fine way of letting no one draw

near, of staying upright, alone, in the high place of the one who gives, with the hand always held out away from oneself and never turned towards receiving.

At night, at home, alone, Dádiva sat in the front room, and her eyes went, as they always went without her meaning them to, to the parcel on top of the furniture. Three years. The faded paper, the tied bow, Estima's present unopened. And Dádiva stayed looking at it in another way, with Brandura's phrase in her head, and she saw, for the first time, not an object she had not yet had the leisure to open, but a portrait of her own self: she saw herself, wrapped, with the bow tied, on top of a piece of furniture of life, for years, waiting for a leisure that did not come, not letting herself be opened by anyone, with the love of others on the outside of the paper, gathering dust. The parcel was she. And what was inside, what her daughter had chosen for her with love three years before, was the proof of a love that she, Dádiva, had not let in, that she had refused without even seeing, that she had set on a piece of furniture to gather dust, as she had set, all her life, all the love others had wished to give her and that she had returned with a smile and a there was no need.

She did not open it that night. Not yet. But for the first time in three years she did not look at it as a deferred task; she looked at it as a question, Brandura's question made object: and you, Dádiva, do you let yourself be received by anyone? And she went to bed with the question, and slept badly, the sleep of one who has seen a thing that had been before her eyes for three years and that only that night, by the light of a phrase said by an old woman in bed to whom she had gone to give, she began at last to see. And in the dark, before falling asleep, she found herself thinking a thing she had never thought: that perhaps it was not leisure she lacked to open the parcel, perhaps it was courage, and that perhaps the courage to receive was a thing that could be learned, as she had learned to give, and that perhaps there was still time, at forty-eight, to learn the other half of what the whole village believed she already knew entire, which was to love.

CHAPTER TWO

The shame that could be seen from the street



Dádiva learned not to receive in a house where a great deal was received, and that was the knot: that everything that came into that house came from outside, by favour, and came in with a shame that could be seen from the street.

The house of Dádiva's mother was one of the poor ones of the village, one of those that live on what others give, and the mother, Conceição — her name means conception, the giving of life — was a woman of receiving her whole life, not because she wished it, but because there was no other way: she received the bread that was left over in the big houses, she received the clothes the children of others no longer wore, she received the charity disguised as a loan and the loan disguised as charity,

and she received all this with a deep shame, a shame that bent her back and lowered her eyes, a shame that Dádiva, as a child, saw in her mother each time someone stopped at their door with a thing to give.

And she saw it in a way she never forgot: she saw her mother open the door, understand that another gift from outside was coming, and make herself small, shrink, say thank you with a voice that begged pardon for existing, and take what she was given as one takes hold of an ember, quickly, so that the humiliation of receiving should last but a moment in her hands. And then, the door shut, the mother would stand a moment still, with the received thing in her hands, and on her face was a shadow that Dádiva learned to know before she could name it, the shadow of one who has been forced, once again, to hold out a hand, and the child, in the corner, looked at that shadow on her mother's face and decided, without words, the way children decide the things that govern their whole lives: not me. I shall not be like this. I shall not receive. I shall be on the other side.

There was one scene, in particular, that stayed in Dádiva above all the others, and it was small, one of those that seem nothing. It was one of those winters when the river Fundo ran down

frozen and the serra woke white, and Conceição had put the pot on the fire with more water than flour, which was the arithmetic of the houses below in the bad months, when there came a knock at the door. To their door came the maid of a big house, Felismina, a girl with red hands and a starched apron who served in the house of the Provenças, the people of the mill, and she carried a basket covered with a striped cloth. The child Dádiva, who was about six, was the one to open, and she stood looking at the basket, and the basket smelled of fresh bread and of chouriço, a smell that into that house came only from outside, and Felismina, with no malice at all, with the indifference of one carrying out an errand who has three more to do before noon, said over the head of the little girl, to the mother who was coming from the kitchen wiping her hands on her apron: my lady Dona Aurora sends this for the poor of the lower street, and she said for your mother to see that the cloth comes back whole, for the cloth is from there.

And Dádiva's mother, on hearing that, the poor of the lower street, stopped halfway through the gesture of wiping her hands. The child saw her stop. She saw her understand, in an instant, that it was she, that she was the poor of the lower street, that this was how the houses above called them when they

spoke of them at table, faceless, nameless, a sack into which one tipped what was left over; and she saw her mother lower her head and say thank you, Dona Felismina, thank the lady, and say Dona to the maid, which was one of the fine humiliations of those who are below, to address as Dona one who serves us a basket of crumbs. Felismina did not even notice; she set the basket on the floor, at the entrance, not on the table, on the floor, like one leaving a thing for an animal, gathered up the cloth she had brought over the top and that was from there and would go back there, and went off pulling her shawl against the cold, on her way to the next house. And Conceição stood with the basket at her feet, and had to bend down to lift it, and the child Dádiva, in the corner, saw her mother fold herself to the ground to pick up the leavings of another house, and it was that image, the mother folded to the ground at the door of her own house, head bowed, picking up off the ground the bread that was thrown to her, that engraved itself in the child too deep ever to come out: the shame that was not hers and that was hers forever. And she decided, in that instant, with more force than ever, with the force with which children decide the things that govern their whole lives, that never, never would anyone call her the poor of the lower street, that she would be on the side of the one who

sends the basket, of Dona Aurora who did not even come to the door, and not on the side of the one who picks it up off the ground with head bowed, cost what it might.

And there was, that same winter, another scene that came to join the first and that Dádiva kept beside it, and it was at table, at night. Conceição had opened Felismina's basket and put the things away, and the bread of the big house was on the table, and Dádiva's father, Joaquim, a man of few words who worked by the day wherever there was work, looked at that white bread, whiter than the bread they baked, and did not put his hand to it. He ate his own, the dark, the home-baked, and when Conceição said to him eat of the other, man, it's better, Joaquim said only, without lifting his eyes from the plate, what is given, woman, always tastes of too little. And Conceição fell silent, and the child Dádiva, who was sharp, understood in that phrase of her father's a thing she spent years digesting: that there was, in what one received, a bad taste beneath the good taste, a taste of being in debt, and that even her father, who accepted the basket because the children had to eat, accepted it with that bitterness in his teeth, with that what is given always tastes of too little; and the little girl decided, eating the white bread that tasted to her of

shame, that she would always eat her own, even if it were the dark, even if it were little, but her own, for at least her own did not have that taste.

Because there were, in the village, the two sides, and the child Dádiva saw them well: the side of the houses that gave, the big ones, the ones above, where the hand was held out away from oneself, full, from above downward, with the ease of one who has; and the side of the houses that received, the poor, the ones below, where the hand was held out to receive, empty, from below upward, with the shame of one who is in need. And the child Dádiva, of the house below, of the hand held out upward, learned that those two sides were the map of the world, and that on one a person stood upright and on the other folded, and that the only salvation, the only way not to have on her face the shadow of her mother, was to pass from one side to the other, was to climb, was to come to be one of those who give, cost what it might, because to give was to stand upright and to receive was to be folded, and Dádiva, more than anything in life, more than to be rich or loved or happy, wished never again to be folded as she had seen her mother folded at the door, with the shame that could be seen from the street.

And she succeeded. That was, at bottom, the work of her life: to pass from one side to the other. She worked from young, first in service, she too, in the houses above, which was where she learned by heart the two faces of the table, the face of the one who orders the serving and the face of the one who serves; she married Bento, an honourable though poor man, a carpenter with good hands and a low voice, and made her house with the sweat of the two of them. And there was a day, at the beginning of married life, that Dádiva kept as one keeps a date, because it was the day she felt, for the first time, the pleasure of being on the other side. They had just finished the first sowing, and there was a surplus, and the young Dádiva, a woman of a little over twenty, filled a basket with cabbages and potatoes and went to carry it, she, to the house of a widow of the upper street who had fallen on hard times, Dona Esperança — hope — who had once been one of those who gave and to whom life had turned the table. And she knocked at her door, and said, hearing herself say it with a shiver of triumph she was ashamed to feel: will the lady accept some cabbages from our garden, for this year it has given too much? And Dona Esperança accepted, with head bowed, with the shadow on her face, the same shadow Conceição had at the door, and Dádiva, on seeing that shadow

on another's face, the shadow on the face of one who received, knew once and for all where she wished to be and where she never again wished to be, and she went home with the basket empty and her breast full of a thing that was half goodness and half another thing she did not wish to name. And from then on she did not stop. As soon as she had enough for herself she began to give, to give to others, to become the one who gives, and each thing she gave was a brick in the wall that separated her from her mother's house, was a proof that she was no longer of the hand held out upward, that she was already of the hand held out downward, that she was already on the good side, the upright side. And the village, which knew nothing of this, which saw only the generous Dádiva, kept confirming the work for her with its praises, you're an angel, Dádiva, and each praise was one more brick, and the wall went up, kept closing. There had been, over the years, hands that tried to draw near and that she pushed away without noticing. There had been a woman, Benvinda — welcome, well-come — owner of the Shop, who in her youth had been a friend of Dádiva's, one of those to laugh with at the fountain, and who had wanted to be a friend in earnest, one of those to share sorrows with; and who once, seeing Dádiva exhausted from caring for everyone, said to her

come to my house one of these days, only to be together, not for you to do anything, unburden yourself to me, woman, you carry it all alone; and Dádiva thanked her, and said I'll come later, and the later never came, because to go to Benvinda's house only to be together, only to unburden herself, was to open herself, was to receive friendship, and that Dádiva did not know how to do, and Benvinda, after a few years of invitations skilfully refused, stopped inviting, and the friendship that might have been stayed at counter acquaintance, cordial and from afar, one more love that Dádiva sent to the outside of the wall without even noticing she did it. And so, brick by brick, invitation by refused invitation, until one day, without Dádiva noticing, the wall that separated her from her mother's house separated her also from everyone, because a wall that only lets out and never lets in does not separate only from the bad, it separates from everything, and Dádiva was left on the inside, alone, upright, yes, but alone, with the love of others on the outside, knocking at the door of a wall she had built against her mother's shame and that had ended by being built against the whole world.

Because what the child Dádiva could not understand, and what the woman Dádiva spent a whole life not understanding, is that her mother's error had not been to receive: it had been the

shame. The mother did not fold from receiving; she folded because she believed that receiving diminished her, because the village had taught her that to hold out a hand was to be less, and it was the belief, and not the gesture, that put the shadow on her face. There were, in the village, those who received with head held high, who accepted a help without folding, who said thank you and stayed upright all the same, because they knew that to receive takes nothing from anyone, that between the one who gives and the one who receives there is an exchange of equals and not a fall; but Dádiva's mother did not know that, and the daughter learned the whole error, with the shadow included, and instead of learning to receive with head held high, which was what her mother lacked, she learned not to receive at all, which was worse, because the mother at least received, and lived, and the children ate; and Dádiva, by refusing to receive so as never to have the shadow, also refused what is good in receiving, love, care, the lap, and made of herself, by dint of not wishing to be her mother's held-out hand, a woman who held out her hand for nothing, neither for the bread of others, which was humiliating, nor for the love of others, which was not, but which she, in her fear, no longer knew how to tell apart.

And this was the saddest of all: that Dádiva, by fleeing her mother's shame, had lost the capacity to tell bread from love. For the mother, they were different things: bread was received with shame, but love, the daughter's, the husband's, that the mother received well, that did not fold her. Dádiva, however, had shut the door to everything that came from outside, without distinction, and treated the love that was wished upon her as she treated charity, drew back from it, returned it, defended herself against it, because in her head, mounted there as a girl, everything that came from outside was charity, was the house below, was the shadow, and she no longer knew that there are things that come from outside and do not fold us, that lift us up, and that love is the chief of them, and that to refuse it, in the name of not being folded, is the surest way to be left, at one and the same time, upright and alone.

The mother had died long since, and had died, as she had lived, receiving, now the care of her children, and Dádiva had cared for her at the end with a fierce devotion. She remembered Conceição's last days with the raw clarity that last days leave: the small room, the iron bed, the mother huddled under the blankets making herself smaller still, as if even in dying she begged pardon for being a trouble. And she remembered a thing

she had said, Conceição, in the middle of one of those afternoons, in a voice already thin, on seeing the daughter arranging her pillow and changing her sheets and doing everything without letting her move a finger: oh child, I don't want to be a weight to you, I never wanted to be a weight to anyone. And Dádiva, who was on the side of giving, as always, answered what one answers, you're no weight at all, Mother, rest; but the mother insisted, with the stubbornness of the dying, I was a weight, child, I was a weight my whole life, to everyone, and she lowered her eyes to the washed sheets, and Dádiva understood that the mother, at the edge of death, was still reckoning the old account, the one of what she owed, of what she had received, of the weight she believed she was; and she did not know, neither that day nor afterwards, how to tell her the one thing that would have set her at rest, which was you were no weight, Mother, whoever receives is no weight, the weight was only in your head. She did not know how to say it because she did not know it, because the daughter carried the same account within, only turned inside out, and two people who believe that receiving is a weight cannot relieve each other of that weight, they can only confirm it.

And even there, even caring for her dying mother, Dádiva was on the side of giving, and the mother on the side of receiving, and Dádiva never understood that the greatest thing she could have given her mother, at the end, was not the care, it was to let her see her daughter receive without shame, it was to show her that the shadow had ended, that the daughter she had wished to spare the cold of the held-out hand had learned, at last, to hold it out without cold; but that Dádiva could not give her mother, because she did not have it, and the mother died seeing the daughter give, give, give, and perhaps died content to see her so much on the upper side, without knowing, poor woman, that she had condemned her, with the name and with the shame, to an upright loneliness that was, in its way, as cold as the held-out hand she had wished to spare her.

It was of all this, or of a part of all this, that Dádiva began to remember in those days, after Brandura's phrase, after looking at her daughter's parcel in another way. She did not remember it in these words, for Dádiva was not one to explain herself to herself; she remembered it in images, in the mother's face at the door, in the shadow, in the maid of the big house, in the poor of the lower street, in the decision of the child in the corner, and there came into her, slowly, an understanding that hurt: that the

wall which had saved her from her mother's shame was leaving her as alone as her mother had been folded, and that perhaps the two of them, the mother who received with head bowed and the daughter who did not receive at all, were after all the same wound, seen from two sides, the wound of a house that learned that to receive is to come down, and that passed that wound from mother to daughter changing only its form, from the shame of receiving to the fear of receiving, which seem opposites and are siblings.

And she thought of Estima, and it hurt her. Because if she, Dádiva, had made of non-receiving her wall, what was she teaching her daughter? What inheritance was Estima taking from a mother who never let her give anything? And Dádiva, who had spent her life fleeing being her mother, understood, with a shiver, that perhaps she was being her mother in another way, leaving her daughter a lack as her mother had left her a shadow, and that the current, whichever it was, of shame or of fear, kept passing, and passed through the unopened parcel on top of the furniture, which was, she understood it that night, not a forgotten present, but a lesson she was giving her daughter without meaning to: the lesson that in that house one does not receive, neither the bread, nor the love, nor a birthday present,

and that to give to Dádiva is to throw a thing onto a piece of furniture where it stays unopened, gathering dust, three years, a lifetime, forever.

CHAPTER THREE

The daughter who wished to give



Estima loved her mother with a full love and bore towards her a small, old resentment, and the love and the resentment were, at bottom, the same thing: Estima wished to give to her mother, and her mother did not let her, and there is no deeper resentment, between those who love each other, than that of not being allowed to repay.

From small, Estima had brought her mother things. A drawing, a flower from the path, a pretty stone, and later, a woman, a kerchief, a sweet, a day of rest, and everything, everything, the mother returned, with the there was no need, with the keep it for yourself, with the I don't need anything. And Estima had grown up with the strange sensation of being, in the relation with her mother, always the debtor, always the one who receives and can never pay, not out of meanness on the mother's

part, who was the opposite of mean, but out of excess, out of a generosity that left no space at all for the daughter's, that occupied the whole side of giving and pushed Estima to the side of receiving and held her there, and Estima, who loved her mother, wished only, once in her life, to change sides, to be the one who gives and the mother the one who receives, and never managed it, and that, over the years, became a deep lack, the lack of a daughter who cannot be a daughter entire because the mother does not let her.

Estima remembered, with the clarity in which childhood wounds remain, a market afternoon, she would have been about nine. For months she had been saving the coins left over from her errands in a glass jar hidden under the bed, counting them at night, and what she wanted, what she had seen on the stall of Faustina, the dry-goods woman, was a silk kerchief with small flowers, the colour of plums, which cost more than she had but for which she had been saving with the fierce patience of children who want a thing very much. She asked her godmother to take her to the market on the right day, she bought the kerchief from Faustina, who wrapped it for her in a thin paper, and she carried it home pressed against her breast as if it were alive.

And on her mother's birthday she stood before her, hands behind her back, her heart brimming over, and held it out to her: it's for you, Mother, I chose it myself, I saved up the money.

And the mother took the kerchief, opened the paper, and Estima saw her eyes understand what it was and at the same time, behind the eyes, the old thing connect, that calculation Dádiva made without noticing it, how much did it cost, at the cost of what, and the mother said, with all tenderness and no malice, oh child, why did you go and spend your little bit of money on me, this is months of money, keep it yourself, you need it more than I do, I don't need kerchiefs, and she folded it again, slowly, in the paper, and put it back in her daughter's hands, with a kiss on the forehead that was to sweeten the refusal and that made it worse. And the child Estima was left with the kerchief back in her hands, still warm from the paper, and with a disappointment she could not explain to anyone, the disappointment of having her present refused with love, which is the most confusing of disappointments, because there is no one to complain to, the mother was good, the mother only did not want the daughter to spend; and she put the kerchief in the jar, under the bed, beside the coins she no longer had, and never used it nor gave it to anyone else, and kept it there for years, her first refused

present, and she learned, that day, a thing that marked her: that to give to her mother was useless, that the mother did not receive, and that her love, Estima's, would have to live its whole life without the pleasure of being handed over. And the kerchief, that one, must return to this story, because there are things that gather under the beds of children and that stay waiting, like the parcels on the furniture of mothers.

Because to be a child is not only to receive: it is also to give, and whoever loves a mother wishes, when her turn comes, to care for her, to repay her, to set her to rest, and Estima wished this with all her soul. She remembered a Christmas, by then a married woman, when she had decided that that year it was the mother who would rest, that the supper would be made in her house, Estima's, and that the mother would be served like a queen, without lifting a finger. She had prepared everything over days, the salt cod the way the mother liked it, the French toast, she had set the table prettily, and she had gone to fetch the mother and brought her, and the moment the mother came into her daughter's house, the moment she saw the kitchen, she went straight to the apron hanging behind the door, put it on, and said let me, child, I'll help, you can't manage all this alone, and got herself into the kitchen, and wanted to fry, and wanted

to wash, and Estima spent Christmas night wrangling with her mother over the frying pan, saying Mother, sit down, today you are the guest, and the mother slipping away from her to the worktop, taking the plates out of her hands, until Estima, in the middle of the supper that was supposed to be the mother's rest, found herself exhausted and hurt, with the mother scrubbing the dishes in her daughter's kitchen while the daughter called her from the table, and understood that not at Christmas, not in her house, not with everything prepared, had she managed to make her mother let herself be served, that the mother carried the apron everywhere like a soldier carries his weapon, ready to leap to the side of giving at the least sign of ending up on the side of receiving. And Estima wished, more than anything, to have her mother seated while she served, wished to do for her what the mother had done for her her whole life, and the mother did not let her sit, did not let her serve, always rose first, always did it herself, and Estima was left empty-handed, watching her old mother serve her, a grown woman, and there was in that a pain Estima could not explain to anyone, the pain of loving a person who does not let us love her back, who accepts our love only in the form of letting us be given hers, and never in the form of giving her ours.

Firmino, Estima's husband — his name means firm, steadfast — a practical man who understood more of engines than of wounds but who loved his wife and saw her suffer, would say to her sometimes, to console her, your mother is like that, don't take it ill, she loves you in her way; and Estima knew it was true, that the mother loved her, and much, but she said to Firmino a thing that was the very heart of her grief: she loves me, yes, but she only lets herself love me. She never lets me love her. And love goes in both directions, or it goes crooked. I am a daughter only one way. And Firmino did not know what to answer, because Estima was right, and because there are wounds in families that are not consoled from outside, that are what they are, and that are cured only if the person who has them, one day, wishes to see them, and Estima's mother had never, in forty-eight years, wished to see hers. There had been one time, Estima told Firmino, when she had wished to take her mother to the doctor of the big town, on account of some pains the mother had in her hands and hid, and she had made the appointment, and arranged the lift, and said to her mother it's all seen to, Mother, you've only to go; and the mother had thanked her and not gone, had invented a sick person who needed her that day, and Estima had understood that her mother preferred to have

her hands hurting to letting her daughter tend her hands, that the mother even hid illness so as not to give her daughter the pleasure of caring, and that this, this extreme, was no longer goodness, it was a stubbornness bordering on cruelty, the involuntary cruelty of one who does not let herself be loved.

The present had been the last great attempt, and the most grieved. Three years before, on the mother's birthday, Estima had decided to give her a thing the mother could not return with the keep it for yourself, a personal thing, chosen with care, a thing that would say Mother, this is for you, only for you, let yourself receive it. She had saved to buy it, had chosen it over weeks, thinking of her mother, of what the mother never had for herself, of what the mother needed and never gave herself, had wrapped it with her own hands, with a bow that took her time, and had given it to her mother in front of the family, on her birthday, her heart full, waiting to see her open it, waiting, at last, to see her receive. And the mother had received the parcel, because one does not refuse a present in front of others, but had said I'll open it at my leisure, and had set it down, and the afterwards had not come, and the parcel had stayed on top of the furniture, three years, unopened, and Estima had understood, with a grief that did not pass, that the mother could not manage

even that, that not even a birthday present, wrapped with love, could the mother receive, and that the mother's wall was so high that not even a daughter's love, set in a parcel, got over it.

At first Estima waited. Each time she went to her mother's house she looked at the parcel hoping to see it opened, and saw it always closed, and went away with the stab. Then she asked, once, twice, Mother, won't you open the present?, and the mother said I'll open it, I'll open it, leave it be, and Estima understood that to ask was worse, that the mother grew distressed, that the parcel became between the two a heavy thing, and she stopped asking. And the parcel stayed there, silent, gathering dust, and became, without anyone saying it, the symbol of all that was lacking between that mother and that daughter: the love Estima could not hand over, Estima's hand held out to the mother and drawing back always with nothing, the proof, set on top of a piece of furniture, that in that house love went only one way, from mother to daughter, and never, never, from daughter to mother.

And there was more, and it was what hurt Estima most, what she said only to Firmino, at night, low: that she was afraid the mother would die with the present unopened. That one day the mother would go, as the father had gone, and that she, Estima,

would be left with that parcel in her hands, opened at last after the mother's death, seeing what the mother had never wished to see in life, receiving alone the present she had given and that the mother had not let in, and that this, that opened parcel after the funeral, would be the last image of the relation of the two of them, the image of a love the daughter wished to give and that the mother carried to the grave unopened. Estima had nightmares about it. She dreamed she opened the parcel at the edge of her mother's grave, alone, and woke crying, and Firmino would ask her what is it, and she would say the present, I dreamed of the present again, and Firmino would hold her and say nothing, because there was nothing to say, except to hope that the mother, one day, before dying, would change, and that hope grew smaller each year.

In those days, without Estima knowing why, the mother began to be different. She went to her daughter's house, one afternoon, a thing she did not do much, for it was always Estima who went to the mother's house, and she sat down, and Estima, surprised, set about serving her, coffee, a cake, waiting for the mother to rise and do it herself, as always; but the mother, that time, stayed seated. She let herself be served. It was a small instant, the mother seated letting the daughter put the coffee before her,

and Estima scarcely breathed, afraid of spoiling it, afraid the mother would suddenly rise and again take from her hands the pleasure of serving; but the mother stayed, and drank the coffee her daughter had made her, and said it's good, child, thank you, and it was the first time in years that Estima heard her mother receive a thing from her without the there was no need, and it was so little, a coffee, and it was so much everything, that Estima had to go to the kitchen so the mother should not see her eyes.

What is it, Mother, asked Estima, when she came back, and asked it with care, because she felt that something had stirred in her mother and was afraid of frightening her. And Dádiva, seated, with her daughter's coffee before her, said a thing Estima did not expect, a thing it cost her to say, because it was among the first times in her life she said aloud a weakness of her own: Brandura said a thing to me, child. She told me that whoever only gives also wears out the one who loves her. And that to receive is a present one makes to whoever loves us. And I've been thinking. All my life I thought that giving was the best one could do for others. And maybe it is, but maybe it isn't enough. Maybe there are people who need to give to me, and I

never let them, and that, child, maybe that was selfishness on my part, it was my wanting to stay always on the good side and not letting you have yours.

Estima heard this from her mother and had to hold herself, because it was the thing she had hoped to hear for twenty years, the thing she had never thought she would hear, and she said only, her voice trembling, that's it, Mother. That's exactly it. I only want, once, to give you a thing and have you let me. And mother and daughter stayed there, in the kitchen, around a coffee the daughter had made and the mother had drunk, and did not say much more, because there was no need, but the two of them understood that something had begun, that the wall had a crack, and Estima, on saying goodbye, thought of the parcel on top of her mother's furniture, and had, for the first time in three years, a small hope: that perhaps, perhaps, the mother would one day open it, and let her be, at last, the daughter who gives.

CHAPTER FOUR

The angel of the village



In Véspera, Dádiva was called the angel, and that was the pretty name that bolted the door on her from the outside: because to an angel no one gives anything, of an angel one only asks, and Dádiva, made an angel by the village, was condemned to a whole life of a hand held out away from herself and never towards.

There had been, a little before, a day when Dádiva felt the weight of the title without yet knowing how to read it. She had been bedridden one morning with one of her bad migraines, the kind that left her in the dark, and had sent word to old Aniceto that she could not come to put his lunch on; and Aniceto, instead of saying rest, woman, I'll manage today, had sent word back, by the neighbour, asking whether she would be able to come in the afternoon, for without her lunch he did not eat. And

Dádiva, with her head splitting, had got up in the afternoon and gone, because an angel does not fail, an angel does not fall ill, and Aniceto had received her saying it's a good thing you came, Dádiva, I was getting worried, and had not even noticed her face, the pallor, the eyes half shut with the pain, because whoever looks at an angel does not see a woman, sees a function that has appeared, at last, to serve him. And Dádiva had gone home at night thinking, without wishing to think, no one asked me if I was well; and had pushed the thought far off, ashamed of it, but it had stayed, thin, waiting.

It was said of her, in the square, at the church doors, in the houses she came into to care: Dádiva is an angel, she's a saint, there's no one like her, what would become of this village without Dádiva. And it was said with truth, with sincere gratitude, because Dádiva did indeed do what was said she did, did indeed come to the aid of half the village, and the village, which received so much from her, repaid her in the only way it knew, with the praise, with the title of angel, without understanding that that title, instead of filling her, emptied her, because it set Dádiva in a place where she was no longer a person, she was a function, she was the one who gives, and to a function one does not offer a lap, one does not bring a soup, one does not care

when it falls ill, because a function does not fall ill, a function does not need, a function is always available, and it was in that place of function, of angel, of saint, that the village, with the best of intentions, with too much gratitude and too little attention, kept leaving Dádiva alone.

Because there is a hidden cruelty in the gratitude that makes a person an angel, and it is this: that by thanking her for the giving, it confirms to her that her place is to give, and takes from her, without meaning to, the right to receive. If the village had said to Dádiva you do too much, rest, let us care for you, perhaps Dádiva would have learned to receive; but the village said to her you're an angel, and against the you're an angel there is no possible learning, because the angel does not receive, the angel serves, and Dádiva clung to the title as one clings to a crown, and made of it one more reason never to lower her guard, never to let anyone care for her, because to let anyone care for her would be to belie the angel, would be to come down from the altar, would be to confess to the village that the saint too was cold, too needed a lap, too was, beneath the function, a lonely woman who gave too much perhaps because she had never learned to let herself be loved.

And there was another thing, deeper, that the title of angel hid, and that Dádiva was now beginning, slowly, to glimpse: it was that giving, for her, was not only goodness. It was also power. Whoever gives stands above whoever receives, stands on the upright side, has the advantage of being the needed one and not the needy one, and Dádiva, who had grown up seeing her mother folded on the side of the one who receives, had clung to the side of the one who gives not only out of goodness, but out of a deep need never again to be folded, to be always above, to be always the one who can and never the one who needs. And the title of angel gave her that, gave her the high place, and that was why it was so hard to let go, because to let it go was to risk being again the girl of the house below, of the hand held out upward, and Dádiva preferred the loneliness of the altar to the shame of the floor, without understanding that between the altar and the floor there was a third place, the level place, the one of those who give and receive by turns, equal to equal, which was the only one where one stands, at one and the same time, upright and accompanied, and that it was precisely that place she had never learned to occupy.

It cost her to admit it, but it was so: there was, in Dádiva's giving, beneath the true goodness, a thread of pride. And she remembered, on touching this, a thing Bento had said to her once, years before, and that she had put away as one puts away what hurts. They had come from the village, and on the way Dádiva was telling, well pleased, all she had done that day, whom she had aided, whom she had carried what to, and Bento, who was walking in silence, said to her at a certain point, without malice, in that low voice of his, you like being needed, Dádiva. And she had taken offence, had said what, I only do good, and Bento had said no, don't take offence, I know you do good, but you like being needed, mind, and sometimes I wonder if you like to give as much as you like not having to receive; and Dádiva had fallen silent, offended, and Bento had never touched the subject again, but the phrase had stayed, and came back now, years after his death, exact like everything he said slowly: you like being needed. And Dádiva understood, at last, what Bento had seen before everyone, that beneath the true goodness dwelt the pride of being the one who can, the one who has to give, the one who is always on the upper side of the exchange. When she came into a house to care, she felt, without wishing to feel it, a satisfaction that was not only that of doing good; it was also that of

being needed, of being the one who is missed, of being, in that house, the important one. And when she went out, with the others' thank-you at her back, she carried with her not only the good tiredness of one who has given, but also, hidden, the confirmation that she was on the right side, the side of the one who gives, far from the house below. And it was that thread of pride, more than the goodness, that prevented her from receiving, because to receive was to let go of the thread, was to come down from the position of one who can to that of one who needs, and Dádiva clung to the thread with more strength than she clung to her own goodness, without knowing that the thread of pride and the rope of loneliness were, after all, the same thread.

There was that week an occasion that showed it to her. Perpétua, a middle-aged woman, fell ill in the village, and what is done was done, the neighbour women gathered in the churchyard at the going-out from Mass to settle who would care, who would carry what, and Dádiva, of course, was the first to speak, to take the heaviest turn, to say I'll take the nights, for me it's no trouble, I sleep by day, and to arrange at once, with the efficiency of one used to ordering these things, who would make the broth and who would take the afternoons. And one of the neighbours, Salvação — salvation — a young woman, lately

married to a lad of the village and still half an outsider, who had not yet well learned Dádiva's place nor the tacit rules of Véspera, stood listening, and at a certain point, when Dádiva had already distributed everything and kept the best for herself, said a simple thing, without malice, almost timidly, but that stayed hurting Dádiva: Dádiva, forgive me, but you always do everything. I came to the village not long ago and I wanted to help, I wanted people to know me by helping too, and you never let me, you always take my place before I get to offer. The other neighbours laughed, without malice too, saying ah, Dádiva is like that, she's our angel, leave her be, and changed the subject; but Dádiva, who had expected the praise of always, took that, and at first almost took offence, almost answered I take no one's place, I only help, what do you want, that I leave Perpétua uncared for so you can make your début?; but Salvação's phrase was sister to Brandura's phrase, and Dádiva, with the chink already open, heard it beneath the offence: you never let others do, you always take my place. And she went home turning it over, and understood, with a new discomfort, that her generosity had a side she had never seen, the side of not letting others give, of occupying all the giving and leaving none over for anyone else, of being so much the one who gives that she took from others the pleasure

and the right of also giving, and that that young woman, who only wished to enter the village by the door of being useful, as everyone enters, had found that door occupied by Dádiva, who was there in front, doing everything, letting no one pass; and that this, which looked like goodness, was, seen from another angle, a way of keeping everything, of not sharing even the place of the one who helps.

Because there are those who give too much as there are those who receive too much, and the two unbalance the exchange, only that the one who receives too much is ill thought of and the one who gives too much is praised, and so the one who gives too much is never corrected, and goes on giving too much all her life, thinking herself ever more virtuous and growing ever more alone, because an exchange where one only gives and the other only receives is not an exchange, it is a dependence, and it wears out both sides, the one who always receives, who feels himself a debtor and diminished, and the one who always gives, who feels herself, at bottom, though she does not say it, used, and who goes gathering, beneath the generosity, a mute resentment, the resentment of one who gives so much and to whom no one gives anything, and who cannot complain, because the fault is hers, who never let them.

And Dádiva, that week, found herself touching that mute resentment, which she had never admitted having, and which was the most hidden part of all. She remembered, without wishing to, a night of the previous winter, when she had come home ill from the rain after caring for old Aniceto, and had arrived soaked and shivering, and had made herself a broth with what there was, and had eaten it alone, standing, at the kitchen counter, with the whole house in silence; and how, in the middle of that solitary broth, a thing had risen in her that frightened her, a kind of anger with no target, and she had found herself thinking, her eyes burning, today I made the broth for three people in this village, and here I am making my own alone, and no one, no one in Véspera at this hour is thinking whether Dádiva has eaten yet. And at once she had been ashamed of the thought, and had pushed it far off as she pushed everything, had said to herself give over with the complaining, woman, you chose this, and had washed the bowl, and gone to bed; but the thing had stayed, at the bottom, in a place she never visited, and came back now, with Salvação's phrase, with Brandura's, and Dádiva understood that beneath the angel, beneath the saint, beneath the one who always gave with a smile, there was a tired woman who, very deep down, asked herself, sometimes, at

night, alone: and me, who gives to me? I give to everyone, and me, who cares for me? And that that question was the proof that giving without receiving did not fill her as she pretended, that it left her, at bottom, hungry, the hunger to be cared for, the hunger to receive, the hunger she disguised as generosity and that was, after all, the oldest hunger, that of the girl of the house below whom no one asked whether she wanted anything, because she was of the poor of the lower street, and to the poor one gives what is left over, one does not ask what they want.

Dádiva went home with the young woman's phrase, and joined it to Brandura's, and to the two she joined Estima's face, the daughter's lack, and the unopened parcel, and she began to see, that week, a portrait of her own self she had never seen: not that of the angel, but that of a woman who had made of generosity a wall, who gave so as not to receive, who served so as not to be served, who occupied the high place of the one who gives so as never to have to come down to the place, which she thought low, of the one who receives, and who had been left, by dint of being always above, alone above, with no one at her side, because at one's side a person stands only equal to equal, and Dádiva had never let anyone put themselves at her side, only below, receiving, or far off, praising.

At night, at home, she looked again at the parcel, and the young woman's phrase joined Brandura's question, and the parcel answered them both: you take others' place, the young woman had said; do you let yourself be received by anyone?, Brandura had asked; and the parcel, on top of the furniture, with the bow tied three years, was the answer to both, was the proof that Dádiva took from her daughter the place of the one who gives, and that she did not let herself be received by anyone, not by a daughter, not in a birthday parcel, and Dádiva, that night, drew near the furniture, and put her hand to the parcel, for the first time in three years she put her hand to it with the intention of opening it, and felt her heart race, and her hand tremble, and the old tightening rise, the tightening of receiving, the cold of the held-out hand, the shadow of her mother at the door, and she did not open it, not yet, she drew her hand back, but she stayed looking at it very close, and said to it low, to the parcel, or to herself, a thing that was the beginning of everything: one of these days I'll open you. One of these days I'll let myself. And she went to bed with her heart still beating from the almost, from the almost having received, and understood, lying there, that to open that parcel was going to be, for her, harder than everything she had done for others her whole life, because giving had always been

easy for her, and receiving, that, that small thing, to unwrap a present from a daughter, was the hardest thing in the world, because it was to come down from the wall, was to risk her mother's shame, was to let in, at last, the love she had spent her life keeping on the outside of the paper.

CHAPTER FIVE

The one who knew how to receive



Brandura taught Dádiva to receive in the only way such things are taught, which is not by words, it is by example: she let herself be cared for with a grace Dádiva had never seen, and in that grace Dádiva saw, for the first time, that to receive could be beautiful.

She went there every day, to Brandura's house, and at first she went as she went everywhere, to give, to do, to tend, with the efficiency of one performing a service; but Brandura, who was bedridden and had time, and who was a woman of seeing people, began to change, without fuss, the way Dádiva was there. She did not let her come in and go out only doing; she set her to sit down, asked her things, thanked her in a way that was not the thank-you in passing, it was a thank-you that looked into the eyes and lingered, and Dádiva, who always gave and to

whom no one usually paid that attention, began to feel, in Brandura's house, not like the one who gives, but like someone who was cared for too, the other way round, because Brandura, even bedridden, even receiving everything, found a way to give Dádiva a thing no one gave her: she let her be a person instead of a function.

And Dádiva noticed, above all, how Brandura received. She received the broth with a relish that filled the one who gave it, said this broth tastes to me of life, Dádiva, with a joy that made the broth worth the trouble; she received the care without diminishing herself, without the shadow Dádiva knew from her mother, head held high on the pillow, with a dignity of one who accepts what she is given as one accepts a right and a grace at once; and when Dádiva did a thing for her, Brandura did not say there was no need, did not draw back, did not return it; she said thank you, how good, and let the good come in, and in letting it come in she made Dádiva feel useful, dear, important, in a way there was no need of others never made her feel.

Dádiva noticed, for example, a small thing Brandura did that left her thinking: when Dádiva arranged her pillow, Brandura did not say oh, don't trouble yourself, leave it be; she said ah, like

this I'm much better, you have good hands, Dádiva, and in saying it she gave Dádiva the pleasure of having good hands, turned a gesture of service into a gesture of care received, and Dádiva left there with that you have good hands warming her, and understood, slowly, that Brandura, by receiving well, gave her, Dádiva, more than she herself gave, and that this was a mystery she had never understood: that whoever receives well gives as much as whoever gives, and sometimes more, because she completes what the other began, and closes the circle, and makes the giving worth the trouble.

There was an afternoon that stayed in Dádiva as an example of everything. She had taken Brandura, without much thought, some figs from the garden, the first of the year, on a cabbage leaf, more from the habit of always taking something than from thinking they were worth much; and Brandura, from the bed, on seeing the figs, opened a girl's smile, and said oh, Dádiva, figs of yours, from your own fig tree, and took one with those already trembling fingers, and ate it slowly, eyes shut, and halfway through the fig she stopped and said do you know, my father had a fig tree, and these taste to me of his, and for fifty years I haven't eaten a fig that tasted to me of anything, and these taste to me of my whole childhood? And she went on eating, unhur-

ried, savouring, thanking with her whole body, and Dádiva, who had expected a thank-you in passing for some figs of no account, stood there watching Brandura eat those figs as if they were the best thing anyone had given her in life, and felt a thing she did not know: she felt that those figs, which were nothing, had become, in Brandura's mouth, an enormous thing, and that it was Brandura, by receiving them so, who had made them enormous, and that she, Dádiva, came away from there richer for having given some figs than she came from many houses where she gave her time and her sleep and where she was dispatched with a hurried thank-you. And she thought, going down the path, that all her life her gifts had fallen into hands that received them badly, hurriedly, with the there was no need that she herself said to others, and that it had never happened to her, until that afternoon, to see a gift of hers received with that grandeur, and that perhaps she, Dádiva, did to her own people what those hurried hands did to her, perhaps she received so badly what she was given that she shrank their gifts, and that to receive badly was, at bottom, a form of scorn, and to receive well, like Brandura, a form of honouring.

And it was there, on seeing Brandura receive, that Dádiva understood a thing that turned her world inside out: that when someone receives well what we give them, they are giving us a thing. That Brandura, by accepting the broth with relish, by thanking eye to eye, by letting herself be cared for without shame, was giving Dádiva the pleasure of having given, was closing the circle, was completing the exchange, and that this, that generous receiving, was worth as much as giving, or more, because without it the giving stays half-done, stays falling into the void, stays like Estima's present on top of the furniture, given and not received, love fallen to the floor for want of someone to pick it up. And Dádiva, who had spent her life thinking that the good was all on the side of giving, saw, beside Brandura's bed, that the good needs both sides, that to give without someone to receive well is like to speak without anyone to listen, and that she, by never receiving, by returning everything, did to those who wished to give to her what no one did to her and what hurt: she left them with full hands and nowhere to set them down, with the love unhanded-over, as she had left Estima for a lifetime.

You know how to receive, Brandura, Dádiva said to her, one afternoon, and said it almost with envy, with the good envy of one who sees in another a thing she lacks. And Brandura, from the pillow, smiled, and said, with the clarity of those who are near the end and no longer have time for roundabout ways: I learned, Dádiva. I was not born knowing. I too was one of those who gave and did not receive, like you, when I was young. I thought that to ask was weakness and that to receive was debt. And she told her, then, a thing Dádiva did not know, a thing Brandura had never told anyone, and that she told there, low, eyes on the ceiling, like one handing over a key before departing. She said she had had a son, an only one, Anselmo — his name means God's protection — who was born ill in the chest and whom she had raised alone because the man had gone early, and that she had spent herself entirely raising him, giving him everything, receiving nothing from anyone, proud of not asking, proud of bearing everything alone, of being one of the strong ones; and that the son had died on her at twenty, in spring, and that she had been left alone in an empty house with a whole life of not having let anyone come near, and that the neighbour women who wished to stand by her in her mourning found a woman who did not know how to be helped, who refused the soups,

who said thank you and shut the door, exactly like you, Dádiva, and that she had nearly died too, not of illness, of shut-up-ness, of a house with no one coming in; and that it was an old neighbour, dead now, Aurélia, who saved her, who came into her house without asking leave and said to her my child, you're going to let me care for you even if I have to do it by force, for I too buried a son and I know that whoever shuts herself up in mourning dies behind him. And I let her, Dádiva, by force, as you let the village in your fever, and it was there, with Aurélia coming into my house without leave, that I learned, late, what it was to receive. I sickened of the body much later, but of the heart I sickened in that mourning, and it was in that sickness that I had to learn, by force, that either I received or I died alone behind my son, and I chose to receive, and I discovered it was no weakness at all, it was the other half of love. Look, Dádiva, whoever only gives loves by halves. She loves others, but she does not let herself be loved, and to love is in both directions, or it is not loving entire, it is only being useful. And you, my child, you are very useful. But I ask myself whether you let yourself be loved, or whether you only let yourself be needed.

That phrase, do you let yourself be loved or do you only let yourself be needed, stayed in Dádiva as few things had stayed, because it put its finger on the exact wound: Dádiva let herself be needed, yes, the whole village needed her; but did she let herself be loved? Did she let anyone want her, not for what she did, but for herself, want to care for her, give to her without her having given first? No. And the difference between being needed and being loved, which Dádiva had never made, opened before her there, beside Brandura's bed, like an abyss and like a liberation: she understood that she had spent her life making sure she was needed, because to be needed was safe, was to be on the upper side, was not to depend; and that she had never let herself be loved, because to be loved was risky, was to be on the side of receiving, was to depend, and Dádiva had a dread of depending, the dread of her mother's house, and so she had traded love for usefulness, and had become very useful and little loved, or rather, loved by many and let by none to love her, which is the finest loneliness there is, that of one who is dear to the whole village and lets no one draw near.

And she understood, that afternoon, a thing that made her shudder: that to be needed could even be a way of binding people, and that to be loved was to set them free. Whoever makes

herself only needed, binds; others stay tied to her by need, by debt, and that looks like love but is a leash. Whoever lets herself be loved, she risks, because love, unlike need, can go away, it chooses, it does not bind; and Dádiva, who had a dread of being left, had chosen, without knowing it, need instead of love, had chosen to bind instead of to risk, and had been left with many people bound to her by need and no one tied to her by the free choice of love, and that was, she understood it now, the difference between the crowd that called her angel and the loneliness in which she went to sleep every night.

Brandura grew worse, in those weeks, and Dádiva cared for her to the end, and it was a gentle end, in Brandura's manner, who received death as she received everything, head held high on the pillow, with gratitude, without folding. Dádiva spent the last nights with her, and on one of them, Brandura's breathing already short, she asked her Dádiva, sit here by me, give me your hand, and Dádiva sat down, a thing she had with Brandura learned at last to do, and gave her her hand, and Brandura held it with her already cold fingers and stayed so, silent, a long time, letting herself be cared for even in dying, receiving Dádiva's company as she had received the broth and the figs, with that grace of one who knows that to accept someone's hand at the

hour of departing is the last present one makes to whoever stays. And in the last days, Brandura, who already spoke little, said to Dádiva a thing that was almost a testament, a parting present, and said it slowly, with pauses to catch her breath: Dádiva, when I am gone, do me a favour. Go home and open your daughter's present. I know you have it there, closed, the whole village knows, three years on top of a piece of furniture. Open it, my child. For your daughter, and for yourself. Don't die as you were going to die, with all the love unreceived, alone on top of your wall. I die receiving, look at me, I die with your hand in mine, and see how good it is, see how it costs nothing, see how it's better than dying giving. Do you the same, but begin early, begin in life, which is better. And Dádiva promised, her voice caught, and Brandura died a few days later, in peace, leaving Dádiva, as a last care, not a thing for her to give, but a thing for her to receive, which was the whole lesson of Brandura's life put into a phrase: open the present, let yourself be loved, do not die with the love unreceived.

And Dádiva came out of Brandura's funeral, at the end of that afternoon, with the promise weighing on her and easing her at the same time, and she went home, and stood at the door of the front room looking at the parcel on top of the furniture, and this

time she did not say one of these days; this time she felt, for the first time, that the day was drawing near, that Brandura, in dying, had left her not only the lesson but the obligation, the sweet obligation of keeping a promise to a dead woman, and that to keep that promise was, after all, to do herself the greatest good of her life, was to open, at last, after so much giving, the only thing left for her to open, which was herself, wrapped for a lifetime, with the bow tied, waiting, like her daughter's present, for someone to have the courage to unwrap her, and that courage, Dádiva understood as she looked at the parcel on the night of Brandura's funeral, was not going to come from outside: it had to be she, at last, who gave herself the permission to receive.

CHAPTER SIX

The patient



It was a little after Brandura's funeral that Dádiva's body did what she never let her body do: it stopped. And in stopping, it forced her to the thing she most feared, the thing she had fled all her life, the thing that was, after all, what was lacking for the book to turn: it forced her to receive.

She had been tired for a long time, with a tiredness she never confessed, because to confess tiredness would be to ask for rest, and to ask was on the lower side; and the weeks of watching over Brandura, and then the death, and the sorrow she did not let herself have because she had no time, were the last drop, and one morning Dádiva, on rising to go and care for who knows whom, felt the world turn, and fell, there, on the floor of the bedroom, and lay a while unable to get up, she who lifted half the village, on the floor, alone, her body telling her enough, the

fever rising, the house silent around her and no one to pick her up, because Dádiva was always the one who picked up and never the one picked up.

And she lay there, on the floor, longer than she should, not only because she had no strength, but because, even fallen, the first thing that came into her head was not to ask for help; it was that no one could see her like that, fallen, weak, on the floor, that she had to get up before anyone knew, that Dádiva could not be on the floor, because Dádiva was the one who lifted others off the floor. And she tried to get up alone, and could not, and dragged herself to the bed, and got into it, and set about hiding it, because even bedridden, even with fever, Dádiva's first instinct was to hide her need, was not to be a trouble, was to go on, even ill, being the one who is no weight.

She managed to reach the bed, and there she stayed, with fever, two, three days, and at first she did what she always did, she hid it, told no one, sent word to those who waited for her that she could not come but that it was nothing, that she was just a little out of sorts, that they should not trouble themselves; because even ill, even bedridden, Dádiva saw to it that no one should trouble themselves over her, saw to it that she should go on not

being a weight, not needing, not receiving, and she lay there wasting with fever alone, faithful to the end to the wall, resolved to fall ill without being a trouble as she had lived without being a trouble, to be, even in illness, the one who does not bother anyone. And there was in this a stubbornness that was almost tragic: a woman with fever, alone, refusing to let the village she had cared for her whole life give her, now, a little of what she had given it, and preferring to waste faithful to the wall than to live with the wall open.

But the village, which had received so much from her, did not let her. It was Estima who gave the alarm. She had thought it strange to have no news of her mother two days running, she who spoke with her mother every day, and had gone to her house at the end of the afternoon, and knocked, and no one opened, and her heart had tightened, and she had gone round by the kitchen, and come in, and found the mother in bed, huddled, burning with fever, with the previous day's dishes unwashed, a thing that never happened in Dádiva's house, and had understood, in those unwashed dishes, the size of what was happening. And the mother, on seeing her, even with fever, even soaked in sweat, the first thing she had said was it's nothing, child, go home, I'll be well tomorrow, I don't want you to trouble

yourself; and Estima, there, at the edge of the bed, with the mother sending her away even ill, had understood at once the mother's whole wound, and had said no, Mother, this time no, and had stayed. And from then on there happened to Dádiva what she had done to others her whole life, and what she had never, never let be done to her: the village came to her aid. The dishes began to arrive at the door, the soup, the messages of get-well-soon, the neighbour women offering to stay, to keep vigil, to care; the half of the village Dádiva had cared for came, now turned in her direction, with their hands full of what she had always given them and never let them give back, and Dádiva, in bed, with fever, saw all that arrive with a panic greater than the fever, the panic of being on the side of receiving, the panic of the floor, the shadow of her mother at the door, and her first reaction, even with fever, was to refuse: there's no need, she said, from the pillows, I'm well, take that away, don't trouble yourselves, I don't need anything.

And there was, among the dishes that arrived, one that disarmed her more than all of them. There was a knock at the door, on one of those mornings, and it was the eldest of the Tristão children, little João, the one whose head Dádiva combed and whose trousers she mended since their mother had died in

childbed, now a lad of twelve, and he carried in his hands, with enormous care, a plate covered with another plate, and said, flustered, red, it was my father who sent it, and I helped, it's a soup, you made us so much soup, Senhora Dádiva, now it's our turn, and my father says for you to eat it all. And Dádiva, from the bed, looked at that child she had helped to raise, bringing her a soup made by his own hands, and it was as if time folded over, as if the care she had poured into the Tristão house over years came back, transformed, in the form of a lopsided soup made by a boy of twelve, and she had to bite her lips so as not to cry in front of the child, and she said only, her voice caught, thank your father, little João, and tell him I'll eat it all; and she ate, afterwards, that under-salted soup full of love, and it was the best soup of her life.

I don't need anything. She said it to the dishes, she said it to the neighbour women, she said it to her daughter, and it was Estima who, that time, did not let her. Estima sat at the edge of her mother's bed, and took the refusal out of her hands with a new firmness, the firmness she had learned to have, and said to her: Mother, now you keep quiet and you let. All your life you cared for everyone, and no one let you be cared for because you wouldn't let them. Now you're ill, and the village wants to care

for you, and I want to care for you, and you're going to let us, Mother, even by force. It's not there was no need. There was need, yes. For thirty years there was need and you never let. Now let.

And Dádiva, weak with fever, with no strength for the wall, did, for the first time in her life, the thing she had never done: she let. She let her daughter put a cool cloth on her burning forehead, and she remembers that, on feeling the cool cloth on her forehead, on feeling her daughter's hand passing it slowly, she shut her eyes and for an instant forgot to draw back, forgot the wall, and it was so good, that cool cloth, that hand, that the tears sprang from her, and Estima, thinking it was the fever, said it'll pass, Mother, and Dádiva did not correct her, did not say it was not the fever, that it was another thing, that it was the forgotten pleasure of a hand caring for her, because she was ashamed to say it, but she let, she let the hand go on, and it was the first surrender. She let the neighbour bring her the soup. She let herself be cared for, and it was, at first, an agony, because each care she received was a stab at the wall, was to come down to the floor, was the mother's shame; but the fever took from her the strength to refuse, and as the days passed and she, without strength, kept receiving, kept receiving, a strange thing began to

happen to her, a thing Brandura had promised her and that she had not believed: the receiving, which she had thought humiliating, did not humiliate her. The neighbour women who brought her the soup did not look down on her, as she feared; they looked at her with love, with the joy of being able, at last, to repay, with the pleasure of closing the circle, and Dádiva saw in their faces, on receiving, not the scorn she expected, but the same joy she herself felt when she gave, and she understood, slowly, with the fever falling and the truth rising, that in letting herself be cared for she was losing nothing, she was giving others the pleasure of caring for her, she was making them the present Brandura spoke of, the present of letting them give.

And there was a moment, in the middle of those days, that stayed in Dádiva: Remédios — remedy — an old neighbour for whose dying husband Dádiva had cared, years before, for months, without ever accepting a coin or a kindness, came to sit at the edge of the bed, and she brought a blanket she had woven herself, a winter one, heavy and warm, and put it at Dádiva's feet without asking leave, and stayed there, silent, keeping her company. And at a certain point, her eyes brimming, she said: Dádiva, you cared for my Augusto like no one, at the end of him, and I could never pay you, because you never let me, and I've

been all these years owing you, and you don't know the weight that is, to owe a person and have her never let you pay, you go about with it on your back your whole life. Let me now, at least, keep you company. Let me give you this blanket, which I made thinking of you, and let me pay you back a little of the much I owe you. And Dádiva, in bed, heard that let me pay you back, and was already about to refuse the blanket, to say oh there was no need, Remédios, that's months of work; but she saw Remédios's face, saw in it a thing that made her stop, saw that if she refused the blanket she was refusing Remédios not a kindness, but the release from a debt of years, was condemning her to go on owing; and she understood, all at once, the weight she had put on others without knowing: that by never letting anyone repay her, she had left half the village feeling itself in debt to her, carrying a debt of gratitude she had never let them settle, people she thought she was relieving and whom she was in fact burdening with the weight of owing her forever. And she kept the blanket. She said thank you, Remédios, it's wonderfully warm, and saw Remédios's face clear, saw the years of debt come off her shoulders there, in that thank-you, and understood that by letting her give the blanket she was doing her a

greater good than she had done her in caring for Augusto, the good of taking her out of the place of debtor where Dádiva's own generosity had put her, the good of letting her be equal.

And Estima. Estima, those days, was the most transformed of all, and Dádiva, from the bed, saw it, and it hurt her and filled her at the same time. Estima cared for her mother with a giving-over that was of dammed-up years, with the fierce happiness of one who has waited a lifetime for her turn to repay and at last has it, and Dádiva saw in her daughter's face, as she cared for her, a joy she had never seen in her, the joy of being able to give to her mother, of being, at last, the one who gives, and she understood, with a tightening of remorse, how much she had taken from her daughter by never letting her give her anything, how much of that joy the daughter had hoped for her whole life and she had denied her, and that it had been enough for her, Dádiva, to fall ill, to grow weak, to lower her guard by force, for her daughter at last to have what she had always wanted, which was to care for her mother, to give to her mother, to be the daughter entire and not only the one who receives.

And Estima, those days, went about her mother's house wearing one of her mother's aprons, making her mother's broths in her mother's pans, and there was in her a girl's diligence, a care to do everything well, to get the salt right as her mother got it, to cut the bread thin as her mother cut it, as if in caring for her mother she were learning, at last, to be a daughter in a way that had always been denied her; and Dádiva, from the bed, saw her daughter in her apron, stirring the broth with her wooden spoon, and it was like seeing herself young, and it was the first time she let anyone use her apron, her kitchen, her place of the one who cares. Mother, Estima said to her, one night, on setting down the broth, with a new shyness, Mother, do you know that this, caring for you, is the thing I most wanted in life? And you never let me. I had to wait for you to fall ill to be able to do for you what you do for me since I was born. And I'm not reproaching you, Mother, I'm only telling you: see how it does me good. See how happy I am, giving you the broth. You always took this from me. And Dádiva, in bed, heard her daughter, and watched her give her the broth with that happiness, and cried, low, with what the fever no longer justified, cried at seeing the good she was doing her daughter just by letting herself be cared for, and understood, at last, in the body and not in the head, the whole

truth of Brandura's: that to receive is a present one makes to whoever loves us, that her refusal of a lifetime, which she had thought generosity, had been a theft, the theft of the pleasure of giving from all those who had wished to give to her, and above all from her daughter, from Estima, who had waited a lifetime for the turn to care for her mother and to whom the mother, with her wall, had always denied it.

And when, after a few days, the fever passed and Dádiva got up, she got up another, not cured of the wall, for such things are not cured in a fever, but with a crack in it through which had come in, at last, a truth that did not go out again: that she had been, those days, on the side of receiving, the side she had feared her whole life, and that she had not fallen to her mother's floor, that she had not had the shadow, that she had, instead, received love and given, in receiving, joy to those who loved her, and that that side, the side of receiving, was not the floor she had thought, it was a good side, a side of being a person, the side she had lacked occupying in order to be, at last, entire, and not only upright and alone on the top of the wall she had built, as a girl, against the shame of a mother at the door of a poor house, a whole lifetime ago.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The keeper of the register



Already up from the fever, still weak, Dádíva went to the House of the Register to see to a paper of Brandura's, who had died with no children near and for whom Dádíva, as always, had offered to close things; and so it was, seeing to the papers of a dead woman she had cared for, that Dádíva sat down before the Keeper, in the midst of the books where Véspera keeps who gave and who received.

The House of the Register was cool and smelled of old paper, and the shelves rose to the ceiling full of thick-covered books, each its own year, and there was there, in those books, the whole memory of the village, who had been born, who had married, who had departed, and also, in the margins and the lists, who had given and who had received, because in Véspera, in the old days, everything was set down, even the helps of the big

houses to the poor, even the inscriptions on the bread lists, and the books kept, without meaning to, the old map of the two sides, the upper and the lower, that Dádiva had carried in her body since she was a girl.

The Keeper, who saw people as she saw the entries, with a look that read between the lines, saw to Brandura's paper, and then, instead of dismissing Dádiva, stayed looking at her, and said: I heard you'd been bedridden. And that the village came to your aid. And that you, for the first time, let it. Dádiva, surprised that the Keeper knew, or not so surprised, for in Véspera everything is known, said yes, that she had been ill, that the village had been good. And the Keeper said, with that dryness that in the Keepers is a form of tenderness: it was the first time you received, was it not, Dádiva. At forty-eight. It took a fever for the saint to lower her guard.

And Dádiva, who had expected perhaps a praise for the illness well borne, took the truth, and the Keeper, seeing her disconcerted, rose, and went to a shelf, and took out an old book, of worn leather cover, with the year engraved on the spine, the year when Dádiva was small, and opened it on the table, blew the fine dust off the top of the leaves, and searched with her fin-

ger until she stopped at a page, and turned it towards Dádiva, and said: look. And it was the page of the year of Dádiva's mother, of Conceição, and the Keeper passed her finger over some entries, and Dádiva saw her mother's name, Conceição, daughter of people of the village, written in the old hand of a dead Keeper, and beside it, in entries of other hands, the records of what in Véspera was set down of the poor houses, the helps, the supports of the parish council, the inscriptions on the lists of those who received the bread of the big houses; and Dádiva saw, on that page, a line that stopped her heart: Conceição, of the lower street, inscribed on the bread list of the house of Dona Aurora, and the date, and the winter, and Dádiva recognised the winter, it was that of the basket, that of Felismina, that of the poor of the lower street, and there it was, set down, cold, in black and white, what she had carried in raw flesh for a lifetime, her mother registered forever on the side of the one who received. And the Keeper said: your mother is here many times, Dádiva. On the side of the one who received. Her whole life. And you grew up seeing this, seeing your mother on this side of the book, and you swore to yourself you would never be here. And you are not. You, in my book, are always on the other side, the side of the one who gives. But see one thing.

And the Keeper turned the pages, and showed Dádiva the entries of the houses that gave, the big ones, and said: these houses, the ones above, the ones that gave your mother the bread, thought themselves above her. They gave from above downward, with the ease of one who has, and some gave with goodness and others gave with scorn, but all gave from above. And your mother received from below, with shame. And you looked at this, as a girl, and decided to be one of these, of the ones above, of the ones who give. But what you did not see, Dádiva, is that between giving from above and receiving from below there is a third place, which is not in this book because the book sets down only the houses, it does not set down the hearts: it is the place of the one who gives and receives without climbing or coming down, equal to equal. Your mother was not folded because she received; she was folded because she thought that receiving put her below. And you are not upright because you give; you are alone because you think that receiving would put you below. They are the same belief, child. Your mother and you believe the same thing, that to receive is to come down. Only she received coming down, and you, so as not to come down, stopped receiving. And you ended as alone above as she ended folded below.

Dádiva heard this from the Keeper and it was as if a veil were lifted from her, because it was the thing she had begun to glimpse with Brandura and with the fever, said now with the cold clarity of one who reads the books of the village: that she and her mother were the same wound, the mother receiving with head bowed, she not receiving at all, the two believing that to receive is to come down, the two caught in a map of the world of only two sides, the upper and the lower, without the third, the level, the equal to equal, where one stands, at one and the same time, upright and accompanied. And she understood that she had spent her life fleeing her mother and being her mother, that the wall which had saved her from the shame had left her as alone as the shame had left her mother, and that the only way out was not to give more, for that only raised the wall higher, it was to learn to receive without feeling herself below, which was the thing neither her mother nor she had learned, and which was, after all, the key to everything.

And there was a thing, on the page, that the Keeper did not remark and that Dádiva saw alone, and that stayed with her: it was that, beside the entries of the helps her mother had received, there was, in later years, the name of Dádiva, now on the side of the one who gave, on the side of the houses that helped, and

Dádiva understood, seeing her own name pass from the lower side to the upper side over the pages, that she had succeeded, yes, in what she had sworn as a girl, that she had climbed, that she had changed sides, that the book confirmed it; and she understood, in the same instant, that her victory had also been her prison, that by climbing so resolutely to the side of the one who gives she had closed herself forever to the side of the one who receives, and that the book of the village, which seemed to prove her right, gave her, read with care, the sentence: here is Dádiva, said the book, who managed never to be on the side of receiving, and who therefore was left without ever receiving anything, not even what does good.

And there was, before the Keeper closed the book, a small gesture that stayed in Dádiva. The Keeper, seeing her bent over the page, over her mother's name on the side of the one who received, did a thing that was not of the office, that was in no book: she stretched out her hand across the table and laid it on Dádiva's, slowly, and left it there, and said, in a lower voice, this house registers who gave and who received, Dádiva, but I, who have been here so many years watching the lives go by, have learned a thing the book does not say: that the saddest lives that pass through here are not those of who received much, they are

those of who never let themselves receive anything. Those are the ones that hurt me to register. And Dádiva felt the Keeper's hand on hers, and her first instinct was to draw hers back, for even a hand cost her to receive, but she did not draw back, she let it stay, and it was one more time that she let herself, one more brick falling, there, in the House of the Register, with the hand of a Keeper laid on hers over her mother's name.

Your mother died receiving and feeling herself below, said the Keeper, closing the book. You are on the way to dying without receiving, and feeling yourself above, and alone. There is a third path, Dádiva, and you tasted it this week, in the fever, without meaning to: you received, and you did not feel yourself below, you felt yourself loved. It was the first time. Now the question is whether you have the courage to do it on purpose, in health, without the fever forcing you. Because to receive out of obligation, in bed, with no strength, that life forces on us all one day. To receive by choice, on your feet, with strength, that is the courage. And it will ask more courage of you, to open a door to let in, than a whole lifetime asked of you in opening doors to give. But that is the one you lack, child. The one of the entrance.

Dádiva left the House of the Register with her mother in her head, and crossed the square, and went to sit on the rim of the fountain of Véspera, the old stone fountain where the women of the village had gone to fetch water since before the memory of any of them, and stayed watching the water run from the spout into the basin, listening to its gentle sound that never stopped. And she noticed, sitting there, a thing she had never noticed in fifty years of going to that fountain: that the water that came out of the spout, the water the fountain gave, the water that filled the pitchers of the whole village, came from somewhere, came from above, from the serra, from the hidden springs, from the rain that had fallen months before and that the earth had kept; and that if the springs ran dry, if the serra stopped sending its water under the stone, the fountain, however old and however generous it was, stopped giving in a day. And the fountain of Véspera, that day, said to her so, by that running water, a thing she had never thought: that a fountain is not only the water it gives; it is also, and first, the water it receives, from the serra, from the rain, from the springs, and that a fountain that only gave and never received ran dry in a day, because the giving of a fountain lives on its receiving; and that she, Dádiva, who had wished to be a fountain of giving for half the village, went about

dry within precisely for that reason, for never having let anything in, for having wished to be a fountain without a spring, a fountain that only gives, which is a thing that does not exist in nature, because in nature everything that gives, receives, and only men, in their stubbornness, invent the giving without receiving and call that virtue, and run dry. And Dádiva put her hand into the cool water of the basin, and let it fill the cup of her hands, and drank, she who gave half the village to drink and never remembered being thirsty, and the water tasted to her of a thing old and good, and she rose from the fountain with her clothes a little wet and with a decision forming beneath the fear.

And Dádiva went home, that afternoon, with the truth of the Keeper and that of the fountain and that of Brandura, all of them saying the same thing through different mouths, and she looked, on coming in, at the parcel on top of the furniture, and the parcel was the door of entrance the Keeper spoke of, the only door of Dádiva's house that gave inward and not outward, and it had been closed for three years, with the bow tied, waiting for the mistress of the house to have, at last, the courage she lacked, the courage not of giving, of which she had plenty, but of receiving, of letting in, of opening, to a daughter's love, the door

she had kept bolted her whole life against a mother's shame, and which was, now she knew it, the only door left to open to stop being, at last, alone on top of her own wall.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The wall resists



Health recovered, strength recovered, Dádiva did what people do when the body stops forcing them to change: she went back to her old habits, and the wall, which the fever had opened, set about shutting itself again, because walls, when they feel they are going to fall, rise with greater force.

The moment she could get up, Dádiva went back to the service of others with a haste that was suspect, the haste of one fleeing again. She went back to caring, to giving, to offering herself, to standing on the side of giving, and the village, relieved to have its angel back, received her with praises, Dádiva's well again, thank God, she's already about caring for everyone; and Dádiva, in the praise, felt the old comfort, the comfort of the high place, and went settling back into it, and each service she did was a

brick put back in the wall, and what she had received in the fever, the care, the love, the joy of letting them give, began to seem to her, now on her feet, with her guard up again, a weakness of when she was ill, a thing the fever had made her do and that health ought to correct.

Because this is what walls do, and Dádiva was living proof of it: they take advantage of health to rebuild themselves. In weakness, a person receives, because she has no strength to refuse; but the moment she recovers her strength, the first thing fear does with it is raise the wall again, shut the door again, and call that going back to normal. And Dádiva, in going back to normal, in going back to giving and refusing, felt she was doing what she ought, that the weakness had passed and that she was herself again, without understanding that the self she was going back to was precisely the illness, the illness of the wall, and that the days of the fever, in which she had received, had been, those, the days of health, the health of the heart, which she now traded, without noticing, for the health of the body and the illness of the soul.

And when the neighbour women, who had enjoyed caring for her and had learned the way, still brought her, by new habit, a thing, a dish, a thank-you, Dádiva, on her feet, recovered, went back to the there was no need, went back to drawing back, went back to returning, and did it now with a new force, almost with harshness, because she had to push harder against what the fever had opened in her, had to shut quickly the door that had been open. There was one morning, in particular, that stayed: Remédios, the one of the blanket, came to her door with a plate of fritters, pleased, with the new pleasure of one who had learned to be able to give to the angel, and said Dádiva, I made fritters, I thought of you, and held out the plate; and Dádiva, by now recovered, by now with the wall up again, instead of the thank-you she had learned in the fever, drew back, put her hands behind her back in the old gesture, and said oh Remédios, there was no need, take that to your own people, I don't eat sweets, and Remédios was left with the plate in the air, halfway through the gesture of giving, and lowered it slowly, and her face changed, and she went away without saying anything more, and carried the plate back home, and Dádiva shut the door and felt the old comfort of the wall and beneath it, thin, a discomfort, because she had seen, in that half-second,

Remédios's face close, she had seen what she was doing, and it was the first time she drew back knowing she was drawing back. And the neighbour women, who had come towards her with pleasure, felt the door shut in their faces, and drew back, hurt, and said among themselves Dádiva's well now, she doesn't let any more, it was only in the illness, and went back to leaving her alone above, which was what she, without knowing it, was asking for again.

Estima was the one who most suffered the relapse. During the illness, Estima had at last had the mother who let herself be cared for, and it had been the happiest thing of her life; and now, with the mother well, she saw her shut the door again, saw her go back to the I don't need anything, child, saw her refuse again everything she tried to give, and Estima, who had at last tasted the pleasure of giving to her mother, felt it taken from her again, and it was worse for her than ever, because now she knew what she was losing, now she had tasted it, and the mother's relapse was not, for Estima, only going back to the usual: it was losing a thing she had had, which is always worse than never having had it.

And there was, between the two, a night of truth that was the bottom of the book. The thing that brought it was small, as the things that bring the great ones always are: Estima had made her mother a dress, had sewn it herself, with the cloth chosen thinking of the colour that suited the mother, and had gone to take it, pleased, and had said Mother, I made you this, try it on; and Dádiva, recovered, with the wall up again, had taken the dress, thanked her, and said it's lovely, child, but you keep it, it suits you, I'm too old now for new dresses, I wear what I have, and had folded the dress and returned it, with the old gesture, with the old smile that was a door closing. And Estima, who during her mother's illness had tasted the pleasure of her mother letting herself be given to, and who now carried the dress back in her hands as she had carried the kerchief at nine, felt burst within her a thing that had been dammed up for a lifetime, and she did not keep quiet, and this time she did not keep quiet. She set the dress on the table, and said to her, her eyes burning, Mother, I don't understand you. You were ill and you let me care for you, and it was the most beautiful thing that happened between us in twenty years, and I thought something had changed. And now you're well, and you've shut everything again, and you've gone back to not letting me give you anything, and I

feel myself outside again, Mother, the daughter who can't be a daughter again. Do you prefer to die alone on your pedestal to letting me love you? Is that it? Do you prefer to be the saint who needs no one to being my mother, who lets me care for her? Because I don't want a saint, Mother. I want a mother. And a mother lets herself be loved.

And she said more, and it was what hurt Dádiva most, because it touched the parcel: and that present, Mother. It's been there three years. I don't even ask you to open it any more. But look hard at it, Mother, before I go. That is me. It's my love for you, wrapped, on top of a piece of furniture, three years, that you never wanted to open. And if you die without opening it, Mother, I'll be left with that image for the rest of my life: that of the love I wished to give you and that you left unopened until you died. Don't do that to me, Mother. Please, don't do that to me.

And Estima went out, crying, and Dádiva was left alone in the front room, with her daughter's fever still in the air, and looked at the parcel, and it was the hardest night of the book, because that night Dádiva had before her, in all its force, the two Dádivas: the one of the wall, which said shut, protect yourself, giving is safe, receiving is your mother's floor, don't come down;

and the one of the fever, the one who had received and had not fallen, who had heard Brandura and the Keeper and the fountain, who had seen her daughter's happiness in caring for her, and who said open, come down from the wall, let in, don't die alone above. And the two Dádivas fought, that night, before the parcel, and the one of the wall was strong, was of a whole lifetime, was the oldest; but the one of the fever had now, on her side, her daughter's face going out crying, the promise to the dead Brandura, the truth of the Keeper, and she had, above all, a thing the wall had no answer for: the question of what the wall was for, if its price was to die alone with the daughter's love unopened on top of a piece of furniture.

What is the use of standing upright, Dádiva asked the wall, that night, if I stand upright and alone, and my daughter goes out of my house crying because I won't let her love me? What is the use of owing nothing to anyone, if the price is to receive nothing from anyone, not even a daughter's love? You, wall, saved me from my mother's shame, and I thank you. But you are costing me my daughter. You are costing me Brandura, who died asking me to open that. You are costing me myself, who go about dry within from so much giving and never receiving. And I no longer want to pay you that price. And the wall, like all walls set

before the question of what they are for, was left with no answer, because walls know how to defend but do not know how to say what the defence was worth, and Dádiva's defence, she saw it now, had cost her a whole lifetime of company, in exchange for a safety that after all had never saved her from anything, had only left her alone above.

And she understood, that night, a thing that decided her: that the wall no longer protected her from her mother, because her mother had been dead for years; it protected her only from herself, from her own possibility of being loved, and that to go on defending it was to go on defending herself from love, was to choose, out of fear of a girl's shame, the loneliness of a woman's life, and that this, said so, before the parcel, on the night her daughter had gone out crying, was of a sadness so great, and of a uselessness so plain, that Dádiva, for the first time, could not defend the wall nor herself, and stayed there, in the dark, surrendered, not yet able to open the parcel, but already unable to go on justifying having kept it closed.

She rose from the chair, in the dark, and went to the furniture where the parcel had stood for three years, and the house was silent, only the kitchen clock counting, and outside a dog bark-

ing far off, and Dádiva stood before the furniture as one stands before a grave or an altar. She did not open the parcel that night, not yet, but she went to it, and took it up, and for the first time did not draw her hand back; she took it with both hands, lifted it from the furniture where it had taken root, felt beneath it the clean rectangle on the wood, without dust, the mark of three years of stillness, as if the furniture itself kept the place; and she stayed with the parcel in her hands, in the dark of the front room, feeling the small weight, the light weight of her daughter's love of three years before, and ran her fingers over the bow Estima had tied, and the dust came off on her fingers, and she said to it, to the parcel, or to her daughter, or to herself, a thing that was already almost the surrender of the wall: tomorrow. Tomorrow I'll open you. I can't die like this. I can't do this to you, child. And she went to bed with the parcel still on top of the furniture, but with the decision taken beneath the fear, the decision to come down at last from the wall, to open at last the door of entrance, to receive, at the end of a life of giving, the only thing left for her to receive, which was the love her daughter had been putting into her hands for three years and that she, out of fear of coming down to her mother's floor, had never had the courage to let in.

CHAPTER NINE

The permission



The courage Dádiva spent a lifetime not having, that of receiving, did not come to her all at once nor by one great gesture; it came in pieces, in small gestures, and the first was so small and so hard that she knew, on doing it, that it was the hardest thing she had done in life.

She had promised herself to open the parcel the day after Estima's night, and when the next day came she did not open it, because she understood, on going to the furniture, that she was not ready, that to open the parcel all at once, after three years, was to leap an abyss, and that she, who had never received anything, did not know how to receive all at once the whole love of a daughter wrapped up three years before; she needed to learn first, with small things, to let in, before she could let in that. And that is what she did. She decided, with the cold clarity of one

who knows herself, that she was going to train at receiving, as one trains a muscle never used, slowly, with small things, until she had strength for the great one.

And she was not ashamed to think of it so, as a training, because she understood that it was exactly that: that most people learn to receive when small, naturally, receiving from their parents without thinking of it, and that she, whom childhood had taught the opposite, had to learn it already a woman, by force, on purpose, like one who learns to read late, with effort and without shame of the effort, because what is shameful is not to need to learn a thing late, it is to die without having learned it out of pride at not needing it.

And the training was this, and it was heroic for being so tiny: she began to let herself be given to. And the first was with Remédios, and it was on purpose, because Dádiva, who was just, knew she had to begin by mending what she had spoiled. She went to Remédios's house, she who never went to receive at anyone's house, and knocked at her door, and Remédios opened half-suspicious, still with the fritter stuck in her throat; and Dádiva said, her heart leaping, Remédios, the other day I refused your fritters, and I did wrong, and I've come to ask your

pardon, and to see if you still have any, for after all I'd very much like to eat a fritter of yours. And Remédios looked at her, and understood what that cost, and opened a smile, and said of course I have, woman, come in, and sat Dádiva at her table, and set the fritters before her, and Dádiva ate one, and another, and said they're wonderful, Remédios, and Remédios filled with pleasure, and Dádiva came away from there with her stomach full of fritters and her breast full of a new thing, and understood that she had mended, with two fritters eaten at a neighbour's table, more than she mended with a thousand services. And from then on she forced herself. When a neighbour brought her a thing, instead of the there was no need, Dádiva forced herself to say thank you, and to take the thing, and to keep it, and it was an agony, each time, to feel the hand held out towards her, to feel herself on the side of receiving, but she forced herself, and said thank you, and the sky did not fall, and the neighbour went away pleased, and Dádiva was left with the thing in her hands and her heart beating from the effort, and thought I managed it, I received, and I did not come down to the floor, and I'm standing upright all the same. And each time she received a small thing without returning it, the door of entrance, which had been bolted a lifetime, bent a little its rusted hinge, and Dádiva went

discovering, with surprise, that to receive did not diminish her, that people did not look down on her for accepting, that they looked at her, on the contrary, with more love, because in receiving from them she let them in, and whoever lets us in becomes nearer to us, and more loved, than whoever only gives us and never lets us give them anything.

There were relapses, because there always are. There was one morning, in the Shop, when Benvinda, weighing out her sugar, said to her Dádiva, you look well, you're prettier these days, and Dádiva, without thinking, returned the compliment at once, what prettier, woman, I'm old, give over with that, in the old gesture of not letting the compliment in, of throwing it back before feeling it; and only on leaving the shop did she notice it, did she hear herself refusing, and she stopped in the middle of the street, and thought there I went again, I returned the compliment again. And then she did a thing she would never have done before: she turned back, came into the Shop again, and said to Benvinda, flustered, Benvinda, just now you told me I was looking prettier and I sent the thing back to you, and I did wrong, and I only wanted to say thank you, it does me good to hear that, thank you. And Benvinda stood looking at her with an astonishment and a tenderness, because she had known Dádiva

for fifty years and had never heard her accept a compliment, and said only, low, you're welcome, woman, and you do look pretty, and Dádiva went out the second time, and this time with the compliment within, warming her. And the new thing was that, was to notice it, was to hear herself refuse and understand that she was refusing, and sometimes to turn back and correct it, and each time she heard herself, the next time she refused less, and the muscle, slowly, with relapses and all, kept gaining strength, and Dádiva kept learning, gesture by gesture, dish by dish, thank-you by thank-you, the thing that her whole life had seemed to her impossible and that was, after all, like everything, only a matter of practising it until it stopped hurting.

With Estima, the training was deeper and sweeter. Dádiva began to let her daughter give her things. She let her make her dinner, once, and stayed eating it while the daughter served, and it was strange to her like everything, to be seated being served by her daughter, but she saw Estima's happiness, and she stayed. She let her take her out walking, let her pay for the coffee, let her, at last, be the one who gives, and each time she let herself, she saw the daughter fill, and understood, once and for all, in the body, what Brandura had told her: that by letting her daughter give to her, she was making her daughter the greatest present, that of

letting her love her mother, and that her refusal of a lifetime, which she had thought protected her daughter from burdening her, had been after all the opposite, had been to deprive her of the love she wished to give, had been to leave her with full hands and nowhere to set them down, three years, twenty years, a lifetime.

Mother, Estima said to her, one afternoon, on seeing the mother accept from her a small gift without returning it, Mother, you're different. You're letting. And Dádiva said, with a new humility, I'm learning, child. Late, but I'm learning. Brandura told me I loved by halves, that I gave and didn't let myself be given to. And she was right. I spent my life giving to all of you, and I never let you give me anything, and I thought that was being good, and it was only being alone. I'm learning to receive, child. And it costs me as never giving cost me. But I'm learning.

And there was an afternoon when Dádiva did the thing the Keeper had asked of her, to receive on purpose, on her feet, in health, without the fever forcing it. She went to the house of Salvação, the young woman, the one who had told her in the churchyard that she always took others' place, and she went on purpose to her house, because it was the one from whom she

had taken the place, and the one to whom she wished, now, to give it back. She knocked at her door, and instead of going to give, she went to ask. She carried in her head a small excuse, a help she did not truly need, that she had invented on purpose to force herself to hold out her hand: she wanted Salvação to help her turn a mattress, a thing she had done alone for thirty years. And she said, at the door, her heart leaping, her voice trembling, with her mother's shadow crying out inside her that she was coming down to the floor, picking up the basket, being one of the poor of the lower street: Salvação, would you mind coming to help me turn a mattress, for I can't manage alone any more? And Salvação, amazed that Dádiva, the angel, the one who always gave, who never asked anything of anyone, should come to ask her, the last to come to the village, a help, opened her door and her heart, and said I'll come at once, and came, and turned the mattress with Dádiva, and stayed for the coffee, and on saying goodbye said, moved, thank you for asking me, Dádiva, and Dádiva understood the size of that thank you for asking me, understood that she had given the young woman, by asking her, the place she had taken from her, that she had made her, at last, part of the village, one of those who are of worth to the angel; and she felt, instead of the floor she feared, a warm

thing, the thing of making someone happy by letting them give, and understood, on her feet, in health, by choice, that the Keeper was right: that to receive by choice was the courage she lacked, and that she, at that door, asking a help she did not need of a young woman from whom she had taken the place, had just had it, for the first time in her life, on purpose.

She went home that afternoon with a lightness she did not know, the lightness of one who has come down from the wall of her own will and discovered that the floor was not her mother's floor, it was a level place, beside others, equal to equal, where one gives and receives by turns and where, therefore, one is not alone. And she looked at the parcel, on coming in, and for the first time she was not afraid of it. The muscle of receiving, which she had trained those days with small things, was stronger; she had already received from neighbours, already received from her daughter, already asked on purpose; and the parcel, which for three years had been the impossible thing, her daughter's love that she could not let in, began now to seem to her not an abyss, but the next step, the greatest, yes, but the next, in the same direction as the small ones, the direction of the entrance, the direction of letting herself be loved.

And she decided, that night, that she was not going to open the parcel in secret, alone, quickly, like one carrying out a thing that costs. She was going to open it with Estima. She was going to call her daughter, and say to her come, child, let's open it together, and she was going to receive the present in front of the one who had given it, and let her daughter see the mother receive, at last, the love she had put into her hands three years before, because to receive the present alone would still be to receive by halves, would be not to give the daughter the pleasure of seeing her receive; and Dádiva, who had at last learned that to receive is a present one makes to whoever loves us, wished to make her daughter that present entire: that of letting her see the mother open, at last, after a lifetime, the door of entrance, and let in what the daughter, for three years, had been waiting for at the door.

CHAPTER TEN

The level place



As Dádiva learned to receive, the village began to notice that the angel had changed, and the change did not make her less loved; it made her, for the first time, accompanied, because a person who only gives stands above everyone, and a person who gives and receives stands beside.

At first the village found it strange. It found it strange that Dádiva, in helping, now let others help too, that she no longer took the whole service for herself, that she said, in caring for a sick person, you take the afternoon, I'll take the night, sharing where before she had grabbed it all; it found it strange that she accepted the dishes, the thanks, the compliments, without returning them, saying thank you where she had always said there was no need; it found it strange, above all, that Dádiva began, now and then, to ask, to say can you give me a hand, to let her-

self be helped, she who had never asked anything. And the village, which had the angel on an altar, saw the angel come down from the altar, and at first it almost felt sorry, as if the saint had become less saintly; but it soon understood that the Dádiva come down from the altar was better than the Dádiva on the altar, because the one on the altar gave from above and no one could reach her, and the one come down gave at the side and let herself be reached, and was more a person, and nearer, and therefore more dear.

Because there is a thing the village learned with Dádiva's change, without putting it into words: that whoever only gives, at bottom, puts us in debt, and debt drives away; and whoever also receives, frees us from the debt, and the exchange draws near. While Dádiva had only given, the village had loved her with gratitude, which is a love from afar, a love of one who owes; when Dádiva began to receive, the village began to love her with friendship, which is a love from near, a love of equals, and that, the passing from gratitude to friendship, was what the coming down from the altar gave Dádiva, and it was more than she had had in forty-eight years of giving without receiving: it gave her people at her side, instead of people below thanking her and people above praising her.

And a beautiful thing happened, which Dádiva had not foreseen: the neighbour women began to care for her in turn. Not because she needed it, but because the relation had become two-way, and in a two-way relation the care goes in both directions; and Dádiva, who all her life had cared without being cared for, came to have, suddenly, women who brought her things, who asked her how she was, who noticed her. There was a Sunday afternoon when Salvação and Remédios and another neighbour, Glória — glory — appeared at Dádiva's house without warning, with a cake and a bottle of sweet wine, and said we came only to be with you, Dádiva, not for you to do anything, only to be; and the four of them sat at the table of Dádiva's kitchen, the whole afternoon, talking of everything and nothing, and it was the first time in years that people came into Dádiva's house not to receive from her and not to keep vigil over her ill, but only to keep her company, as equals, at the table, with sweet wine; and Dádiva, who always served and was never served, let herself be served the cake by Glória, and let her glass be filled by Salvação, and at a certain point, in the midst of the laughter, she found herself laughing too, open-mouthed, a thing she had not done for years, and understood, with astonishment, that she was being cared for, she, for the first time since Bento, not from a sick

bed, but on her feet, at the table, among friends, and that this, instead of diminishing her, filled her, warmed her, made her house less silent, and that after all, in opening the door of entrance, it was not only her daughter's love that had come in, the love of the whole village had come in, which had been all that time on the outside knocking, wishing to come in, and which she had kept out calling it gratitude and fear.

And there was an occasion that sealed the change in the eyes of the village, and it was small and it was everything. Dádiva fell ill of a cold, a thing of nothing, but that left her hoarse and with no wish to go out in the cold there was. And instead of hiding it, instead of the it's nothing, don't trouble yourselves of always, instead of getting up and going to the Shop to cough through the street only so as not to ask, Dádiva did the thing she had never done in fifty years: she went to the window, and called the neighbour next door, Florinda — little flower — a young woman with small children, and said to her, in her hoarse voice, Florinda, I'm out of sorts and I don't feel like going out in this cold, would you mind bringing me a loaf when you go to the Shop? And Florinda, amazed, because it was Dádiva asking her, Dádiva who carried her soup when the children fell ill, said of course, Dádiva, I'll bring it right away, and brought the loaf, and

brought more than the loaf, she brought some eggs and a jar of honey for the throat, and said this is for your getting well, and Dádiva, instead of refusing the honey, instead of the there was no need, said thank you, Florinda, and kept the loaf and the eggs and the honey, and Florinda went off feeling herself of use to the angel, light, pleased, and Dádiva shut the window and was left with that loaf in her hands and with a strange joy at having asked a neighbour for a loaf, she, the one who gave bread to half the village; and she understood that that asked-for loaf was worth, to her, more than all those she had given, because that one had been received, had been letting in, had been to come down to the level place of one who asks a neighbour for a loaf as everyone asks, without diminishing herself, equal to equal, in the place where, at last, she was not alone.

And she thought, with that loaf in her hands, of her mother. She thought that her mother had received the bread of others her whole life with head bowed, with the shadow, and that she, Dádiva, had just received a loaf with head held high, without shadow, with pleasure, and understood that she had done, at last, the thing her mother had lacked, which was to receive without diminishing herself, and that in doing it she cured, in a way, her mother, gave her, late, the bearing her mother had

never had, and undid, in that loaf received without shame, the knot of three generations, the belief that to receive is to come down, that the mother had carried folded and she had carried upright and alone, and that ended there, in a loaf asked of a neighbour on a cold morning, almost without her noticing it, in the way the great things end, in a small gesture.

Estima saw all this, and went filling with a hope she no longer had. There was an afternoon when she went to her mother's house and found her seated at the table with Florinda, the young neighbour, the two of them drinking coffee Florinda had brought, and the mother letting herself be served, laughing at some thing, and Estima stayed at the door an instant watching that, the mother seated being served by a neighbour, and had to breathe deep, because it was a thing she had never seen in forty years, the mother on the side of the one who receives, at ease, without the shadow, and she understood that the change was in earnest, that it was not only with her, that the mother was learning to let herself be received by everyone. She saw the mother change, saw her receive, saw her come down from the altar, and had before her, she knew it, the final proof, the parcel, and she did not ask for it, did not hurry it, because she had learned, she too, that these things are not pushed, but she waited for it, with

her heart, and went to her mother's house and looked at the parcel on top of the furniture, and this time she did not carry the stab of always, she carried a hope, because the parcel was still closed but the mother was no longer the same, and Estima felt it was only a matter of time, that the door that had opened to the neighbours, to the loaf, to the small receivings, was going to open, one of these days, to the great one, to hers.

And it was Dádiva who chose the day. One afternoon, at her daughter's house, after letting her serve her the coffee, after drinking it and thanking her eye to eye as Brandura had taught her, Dádiva said to her daughter a thing Estima had hoped for three years and no longer thought to hear: child, will you come to my house on Sunday? I want to open the present with you. That one. The one you gave me three years ago. It's time now, isn't it? I've learned enough to open it. And I want to open it with you, in front of you, for you to see me receive. Which is what I've owed you for three years: not the opening of it, that's the least of it; it's letting you see me receive your love. Will you come?

And Estima, who did not expect it, had to set down the cup so as not to let it fall, and said only, her voice trembling all over, I'll come, Mother. Of course I'll come. And the two stayed there, in

the daughter's kitchen, around the coffee, saying nothing more, because there was no need, and Estima understood that the Sunday drawing near was going to be, for the two of them, more than opening a parcel: it was going to be the day when the mother, at last, after a life of giving, let herself be received by her daughter, the day when the door of entrance of Dádiva's house, bolted since a girl at the door of a poor house, opened, at last, to let in the love that had been waiting three years on top of a piece of furniture, and that had been, waiting to come in, in truth, a whole life entire.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The eve



On the Saturday night, the eve of the Sunday on which she was to open the present with her daughter, Dádiva stayed alone at home with the parcel, and it was a long night, because the wall, which she was going to bring down the next day, made, as walls that are going to fall make, its last guard.

She sat in the front room, before the furniture, with the parcel in front of her, and stayed looking at it, and the old voice rose, the mother's voice, the voice of the poor house, the voice that said do not receive, to receive is to come down, remember the shadow, remember the door, remember the cold, remember the maid of the big house and the poor of the lower street. And Dádiva heard it, one last time, and this time she did not push it far off; she heard it to the end, with pity, with the pity she had

learned to have for her mother and for herself, and she answered it, in the dark of the front room, slowly, like one who speaks with a dead woman.

I know, Mother, she said. I know that you received with shame, and that you wished to spare me that shame, and that you gave me the name of Dádiva for me to be always on the side of giving, far from your shadow. And I thank you, Mother. You did what you knew, with what you had. But you were wrong about one thing, and I was wrong along with you for a whole lifetime: the shame was not in receiving. It was in your believing that receiving put you below. And I, so as not to have your shadow, stopped receiving at all, and was left as alone above as you were left folded below. And tomorrow, Mother, I'm going to do the thing you did not know how to do and that I too did not know for a lifetime: I'm going to receive with head held high. I'm going to open my daughter's present, and let her love in, and I'm not going to feel myself below, I'm going to feel myself loved. And this, Mother, is not to betray you. It is to cure you, in me. It is to end in me the shame you carried, so that my daughter does not inherit it, neither your shadow, nor my fear.

And that was, that one, the farewell to her mother, the true one, the one Dádiva had never made, and she made it in peace, before the parcel, on the eve of opening it, and in making it she felt the wall, which had defended her a lifetime, come down at last, not crumbling at a blow, but lowering slowly, with respect, the way one lowers an old flag that has served its time, and over the lowered wall Dádiva saw, for the first time, the whole level place, the village beside her, the daughter at the door, the world equal to equal where she was going, the next day, to come down for good.

And there came back to her, that night, a small scene she had put away long since and that now unfolded entire: the day when the mother, already old, had told her why she had given her that name. It had been one afternoon or other, Conceição already with white hair, sitting in the sun at the door, and Dádiva, who was then about thirty, asking her, without much weight, Mother, why did you call me Dádiva, which is an odd name, no one in the village is called that. And the mother had stayed a moment silent, and then had said, without looking at her daughter, looking at the lower street where they had lived through all the cold: I called you Dádiva, child, for you to be always the one who gives. I received my whole life, and you saw me, and I did not

want that for you. I wanted you on the upper side. I wanted that when someone heard your name, they would know at once, without knowing you, that you were one of those who give, and not one of those who ask. It was the best I knew how to give you, that name. And Dádiva, at the time, had thanked her, and thought no more of it; but now, on the eve of opening the parcel, she remembered the mother's face saying that, remembered the sad pride with which the mother had told it, and understood, there, a thing that moved her: that the mother, in giving her the name of Dádiva, had wished to give her a present, the greatest she knew how to give, that of sparing her the cold she herself had known; and that she, Dádiva, had spent her life using that present backward, making of the name a wall instead of a blessing, and that to open her daughter's parcel the next day was, also, to open at last her mother's present, that of the name, to receive it as it had been given, with love, and not as she had carried it, with fear; and that, in receiving, at last, with head held high, she was going to honour her mother better than she had honoured her with a whole lifetime of not receiving, because the mother had not wished her only on the side of giving; the mother had wished her without the shadow, and the shadow,

Dádiva saw it now, is not removed by not receiving, it is removed by receiving without shame, which was what she was going, at last, to do.

She took up the parcel, that night, and held it in her lap a long time, without opening it, for she was going to open it with her daughter; but she held it in her lap, felt its small weight, and stayed looking, by the weak light of the lamp, at the faded paper and the crumpled bow, and tried to imagine what was inside, a thing she had never in three years allowed herself to do, because to imagine was already a beginning of wanting, and to want was already a beginning of receiving. And she thought of Estima choosing it, three years before, going into a shop thinking of her mother, hesitating between one thing and another, saving to buy it, wrapping it at home at night with that bow that took her time, with her tongue out in concentration as when she was little, giving it to her mother on her birthday with her heart full, waiting to see her open it, and seeing it set down, and closed, year after year, on top of a piece of furniture, and Dádiva cried, with the parcel in her lap, of remorse and of love, of remorse for the three years, for the whole lifetime of her daughter's love left unreceived, and of love for that daughter who, in spite of everything, in spite of a mother who never let

her give anything, had gone on wishing to give, had gone on waiting, three years, for the mother to open her present, without giving up, with a faithfulness that was the proof of a love greater than all of Dádiva's wall.

And she understood, with the parcel in her lap, on the eve, a thing that filled her and eased her: that it was not late. That Estima was still there, waiting, on the outside of the door, with the love unhanded-over but alive, not dead; that she, Dádiva, still had time to open the door with her daughter alive and in front of her, and not as Estima had feared, after the funeral, alone, with the parcel opened at the edge of her mother's grave. She was going to open it in life. She was going to give her daughter what her daughter most wished, which was to see the mother receive. She was going to do, the next day, in health, by choice, in front of one who loved her, the thing she had lacked doing her whole life, and which was, after all, the simplest and the hardest of all: to let herself be loved.

She put the parcel back on the furniture, with care, to open it the next day with her daughter, and went to bed, and slept, on the eve, a sleep she did not know, the sleep of one who is going, at last, to open the door of entrance, after a life with it bolted;

and she dreamed of her mother, but not the mother folded at the door, the mother with head held high, receiving a thing from someone and smiling, the mother the mother never came to be and that Dádiva, in the dream, gave her, because in curing in herself the mother's shame, Dádiva cured also, in a way, the mother, gave her, late, the bearing the mother had never had, and the mother, in the dream, received with head held high, and was beautiful so, and Dádiva woke in the morning with that image of her mother and with the day before her, the day of opening the present, the day of receiving, at last, after a life of giving, the love that awaited her, wrapped, for three years, and within, for a lifetime.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The unopened present



The Sunday came, and Estima came, and she came with a girl's nervousness, because she knew what that Sunday was. She had slept badly, and Firmino, who had seen her turning in the bed all night, had asked her in the morning are you nervous about the present?, and she had said I am, and he had said only one thing, go with your heart open, for if she receives today, she receives, and if not today, she'll receive, but don't expect the whole mother all at once; and Estima had gone, with that practical counsel of the man who understood more of engines than of wounds and who sometimes hit the mark dead on. And along the way she kept saying to herself don't expect anything, don't hurt yourself again, but her heart ran ahead, hopeful, and she could not hold it. And she reached her mother's house, and the mother was waiting for her with the

parcel already taken from the furniture and set on top of the table, in plain view, in the middle, as one sets a thing one is going at last to look at head-on; and Estima, on coming in and seeing the parcel on the table, in the middle, and not on the furniture, in its place of always, understood at once that it was in earnest, that the mother had not drawn back, and had to lean against the doorpost an instant for her heart to settle.

The two of them sat at the table, with the parcel between them, and stayed a moment silent, because there were three years in that moment, and there were, before the three years, a whole life; there was the kerchief bought with saved coins that the mother had returned to a little girl, there were all the refused presents, there was Estima's hand always held out and always drawing back with nothing, and all of it was there, on top of the table, inside that parcel of faded paper, waiting to come undone, at last, as the bow came undone. And it was Estima who said, low, her eyes already burning, open it, Mother.

And Dádiva took up the parcel, and her hands trembled, trembled as they had never trembled in giving anything whatsoever, because giving had never cost her and that, to receive, to open, to let in, was the hardest thing of her life, and Estima saw her

mother's hands tremble and understood, in that trembling, all that the gesture cost, and felt the wish to help her, to open it herself, but she did not do it, because it was the mother who had to open, it was the mother who had to receive, and Estima waited, her heart in her mouth, for the mother to do, at last, alone, the gesture that cost her more than a whole lifetime of gestures of giving.

Dádiva took hold of the end of the bow, and pulled, and the bow, which Estima had tied three years before with such care and that had stood there tied all that time, came undone all at once, gentle, as if it had only been waiting for that, as if three years were nothing to a bow that knows it must be undone; and to undo it was like opening a sealed thing, like opening a door that had stayed shut so long the lock had gone to rust, and for a moment Dádiva stopped, with the bow already loose and the paper still closed, and felt at her fingertips the weight of everything, three years, a lifetime, her mother's house, the shadow, Brandura, the Keeper, the fountain, and she almost drew back, almost set the parcel down, almost said I'll open it later, at my leisure, as she had said three years before; but Estima, on the other side of the table, said nothing, did not hurry her, only looked at her, and in that look there was so much waiting and so

much love that Dádiva could not draw back before it, and she breathed deep, and opened it. The paper, faded with time, worn at the folds, gave way beneath her fingers with a dry sound, and Dádiva opened the parcel, slowly, with care, like one unwrapping a fragile thing, and the paper drew aside, and within was a shawl.

It was a shawl of fine wool, soft, of a warm colour, folded with care, and Dádiva, on seeing it, understood at once all that it meant to say, and Estima, seeing the mother understand, said it, her voice trembling: it's to keep you warm, Mother. You keep everyone warm. You care for everyone, you cover everyone, and no one ever covers you. I chose you a shawl so that, at least once, you'd be the one to be covered. So that you'd have a thing of mine around your shoulders, warming you, when I'm not there. It's only a shawl, Mother. But it's my lap, it's my arms, it's the care you never let me give you. And it's been three years waiting to warm you.

And Dádiva stayed with the shawl in her hands, and understood that her daughter, three years before, had chosen her the exact present, the present that said everything: a shawl for the woman who covered everyone and never let herself be covered, an em-

brace of wool for the one who gave a lap to half the village and never let herself be put on a lap, and that that present had been three years unopened not by chance, but because it was precisely that, to let oneself be covered, to let oneself be warmed, to let oneself be cared for, the one thing Dádiva did not know how to do, and that to open it was to receive it, and to receive it was to let herself be, at last, wrapped warm by her daughter, to come down from the wall, to come into the lap, to be the covered one and not the one who covers. And she understood, with a tightening, that her daughter knew her better than she knew herself, that at a little over twenty Estima had already read her whole wound and chosen her the exact remedy, and that that remedy had been three years a hand's breadth from her, on top of a piece of furniture, waiting for her to have the courage to take it.

And Estima rose, and took the shawl from her mother's hands, and did the thing the shawl was made for: she put it around her shoulders. She covered her mother. And Dádiva, on feeling her daughter's shawl wrap her, on feeling herself covered, warmed, cared for, by her daughter, she who had covered everyone and never let herself be covered, felt a thing rise that was not her mother's shadow, was not the cold of the poor house, was not the shame of the held-out hand; it was the opposite of all that, it

was the warmth, it was the lap, it was the love of a daughter wrapping her, at last, after a lifetime, and Dádiva cried, with the shawl on her shoulders, cried as she had never cried, not of sadness, but of a thing that had no name and that is what one feels when one receives, at last, the love that has been kept a lifetime on the outside of the door, and that comes in, suddenly, all of it, and fills, and warms, and one understands how much cold one had one's whole life without knowing, from so much not letting oneself be covered.

Thank you, child, said Dádiva, and it was the first time in her life that she said thank you for real, without the there was no need beneath it, without drawing back, without returning it; an entire thank-you, received, with head held high, with her daughter's shawl on her shoulders, and Estima, on hearing that thank you, understood that the mother had, at last, received, not only the shawl, but the love, that she had opened, at last, the door of entrance.

And it was then that Estima did a thing she had kept for that moment, without knowing whether it would ever come. She took from her bag a small packet, wrapped in a thin, old, yellowed paper, and set it on the table beside the opened parcel,

and said, her voice trembling, and there's one more thing, Mother. And Dádiva opened the little packet, and within was a silk kerchief with small flowers, the colour of plums, faded with time, folded with a care of many years; and Dádiva looked at that kerchief and did not understand at once, and Estima said, it's the kerchief, Mother. The one I bought you when I was small, with all the coins I saved, and that you gave me back, do you remember? I never used it. I never gave it to anyone. I kept it in a jar under the bed, all these years, my first present that you refused, and I brought it today, because today you receive now, and I wanted, at last, to give it to you. Forty years later. And Dádiva, with the shawl on her shoulders and the little girl's kerchief in her hands, understood the size of what she had done her whole life, understood that her daughter had kept for forty years the pain of a refused kerchief, that she had had it under the bed like a wound wrapped up, as she herself had had the parcel on top of the furniture, and that the two of them, mother and daughter, had lived the same life with a present to give and to receive, each with her own, waiting; and she took the kerchief, and put it herself around her neck, over the shawl, and said does it suit me, child?, and Estima, crying and laughing,

said it does, Mother, it suits you beautifully, and it was the first time, in forty years, that that little girl's kerchief fulfilled, at last, what it had been bought to fulfil: to keep the mother warm.

And Estima embraced her mother, with the shawl and the kerchief between the two, and they stayed so, mother and daughter, embracing, around two presents received at the end of a life, and Estima had, in that embrace, what she had hoped for a lifetime: the pleasure of having given her mother a thing the mother had received, the pleasure of being, at last, the daughter who gives and is received, the closing of the circle that the mother's wall had denied her from the beginning.

And it was not only the shawl, and the two of them knew it. It was the door. It was Dádiva opening, with that parcel, the door of entrance of her life, the one she had kept bolted since a girl watching her mother folded at the door of a poor house. It was the shame of three generations ending there, at that table, because Dádiva, in receiving her daughter's shawl with head held high, did what her mother had never known how to do, receive without diminishing herself, and in doing it she cut the current, did not pass it to Estima, left her daughter not a mother who does not let herself be loved, but a mother who learned, late but

in time, to let herself be loved, and that is the good inheritance, the one Estima would carry, and the one she would, perhaps, one day, pass to her own children: that of a house where one gives and receives, where love goes in both directions, where the door of entrance is open.

They stayed the whole afternoon together, mother and daughter, and Dádiva did not take off the shawl, she went about the house with it making the coffee, going to fetch cake, seeing to things, always with the shawl on her shoulders and the little girl's kerchief around her neck, covered, and it was strange and it was good to go about covered, she who always covered others and never remembered that she too was cold, and each time she felt the shawl on her shoulders she felt her daughter, her daughter's care, the love she had received at last, and she understood, slowly, over that afternoon, that Brandura had been right to the end: that to receive is a present one makes to whoever loves us, and that she, in receiving that shawl, had made her daughter the greatest present of both their lives, that of letting her, at last, love her mother. And they talked, that afternoon, as they had never talked, because the open door let pass not only the shawl but the words. Estima told her mother things she had never told her, told her of the pain of the kerchief at nine, told

her of the nights when she cried with Firmino over the unopened present, told her of the nightmare in which she opened the parcel at the edge of her mother's grave, and Dádiva listened to her, and for once did not interrupt her to console her or to turn the subject, she only listened, with the shawl on her shoulders, and in listening understood the size of what her wall had cost her daughter, years of a girl and a woman feeling herself outside, loving a mother who did not let her love her. And she told her own too, the mother, the poor house of the lower street, Felismina's basket, Conceição folded to the ground picking up the bread of another house, the poor of the lower street, the shame that could be seen from the street, the father saying that what is given always tastes of too little; and Estima, on hearing that, understood at once the whole mother, understood where the wall came from, understood that the mother had not refused her, had refused an old shadow she had confused with her, and said, her eyes full, oh Mother, I didn't know, I never knew any of this, I thought you wouldn't let me give you anything because you didn't need me, and after all it was the opposite, it was because you were afraid. And the two of them, that afternoon, came to know each other more than in forty years,

because between one who only gives and one who only receives there is no true knowing, there is only service, and the knowing, the equal to equal, only began when the door opened.

And at the end of the afternoon, when Estima went away, Dádiva stayed alone at home, with the shawl on her shoulders, and looked at the furniture where the parcel had stood three years, and the furniture was empty now, without the unopened parcel, and Dádiva, instead of the strangeness of seeing it empty, felt a good thing, because that emptiness on top of the furniture was the proof that she had opened, at last, the door, that the love that had stood there closed three years was now inside her, on her shoulders, in her breast, received, and that she, Dádiva, the one who gave to half the village and received from no one, was now, at last, at the end of a life, a woman who also received, who let herself be covered, who let herself be loved, and who was, therefore, for the first time since she was a girl, not alone on top of a wall, but in the level place, beside her own, covered by a shawl that was a daughter's arms, and warm, at last, with the warmth she had spent her life giving to others and denying herself, and that now, with the door open, she let, at last, come in.

FROM THE REGISTER OF VÉSPERA

From the register of Véspera

And of everything a record was made.

Be it set down that Dádiva, daughter of people of the village, who had given to half of Véspera her whole life and never received from anyone, opened at last, in front of her daughter, the present she had had three years unopened on top of a piece of furniture, and that, in opening it, she opened more than a parcel: she opened the door of entrance of her life, the one she had kept bolted since girlhood against the shame of a mother at the door of a poor house. Be it set down that she let herself be covered by a shawl that was a daughter's arms, and that she said thank you without the there was no need beneath it, with her head high, receiving, which seems small and took her a whole life, and which is, of the things this Keeper records, among the hardest for one who learned, as a child, that to receive is to come down.

The register keeps who gave and who received, and by it one sees who lived on one side only. This Keeper saw Dádiva's mother always on the side of receiving, bent; and saw Dádiva, the daughter, flee that side and settle on the side of giving, alone above; and understood that the two of them, the one who received coming down and the one who did not receive so as not to come down, believed the same thing, that to receive puts one below, and that it was that belief, and not the gesture, that was the wound of the house. Dádiva healed it, at last, on the day she received with her head high, and in healing

*it in herself she did not pass it to the daughter, and cut there, at that table,
around an opened parcel, a chain that came from far off.*

*Whoever reads this entry and recognises herself in some Dádiva, who cares
for everyone and lets no one care for her, who returns the dishes and the
compliments and the embraces before they reach her, who has at home, to
the letter or within, a present unopened, let her know what she learned and
what this house records: that whoever only gives loves by halves, and is left,
however dear they may be, alone above; that to receive is not to be in debt, it
is to let in, and it is a present one gives to the one who loves us; and that
there is, in every life like that, a door of entry bolted, and that to open it, late
though it be, with the hands trembling though they may, is the greater
courage, greater than a whole life of opening doors to give.*

*Dádiva came down from her wall to the level place, where one gives and
receives by turns, and where, therefore, one is not alone. And the present,
which was three years unopened, is open, and the shawl is on the shoulders
of one who covered everyone and never let herself be covered, and in
Dádiva's house, since that Sunday, love goes in both directions, which is how
love goes when it is entire, and which is what this village, book by book, is
slowly learning.*

*And of everything a record was made, by the hand of the Keeper, in the
register of Véspera.*



For the reader

Thank you for crossing this year of Véspera with Dádiva.
If the story touched you, pass it on, not as proof, but as
seed.

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